

Last-minute requests, cap on gathering: how Delhi Police decides on Jantar Mantar protests

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Over the past few weeks, several organisations – from anti-reservation groups to those opposed to the special intensive revision (SIR) of voter rolls – have sought permission to hold demonstrations at Jantar Mantar. Their requests have been denied amid concerns over “open calls” for protests, uncertainty over crowd size and last-minute requests, said officers familiar with the process. No demonstration has been allowed at the ve-

nue since the stir led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) in July, they said.

On Wednesday, CJP co-convenor Saurav Das submitted an “intimation letter” for a joint protest at Jantar Mantar on October 10 to highlight alleged irregularities in the SIR and demand Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar’s resignation.

The organisers were asked to submit an undertaking, and their request is being assessed, a senior officer said. An intimation letter, however, is not treated as a formal application

for permission, he added.

“Merely informing us about a proposed demonstration does not amount to seeking permission. Organisers are required to approach the office of the Deputy Commissioner of Police concerned 10 days in advance and provide details, including the date, time and agenda of the protest, along with the expected number of participants and other logistical requirements at the site. The request is then assessed,” said the officer.

The assessment takes into account the expected

mobilisation, the organisations involved, the nature of the issue, the possibility of counter-protests, traffic implications and the manpower and equipment required. Whether other demonstrations are planned for the same day or time is also considered.

Limit on turnout
Jantar Mantar is a designated protest site with a stated capacity of up to 1,000 people. The uncertainty becomes greater when organisers issue an “open call” without indicating the likely turnout or who will be

responsible for the gathering, the officer said. Under such circumstances, requests made close to the proposed date can be difficult to accommodate, given the need to make arrangements for crowd management, traffic regulation and public safety.

“An unplanned gathering can disrupt the movement of thousands of other people,” said a second officer, adding that prohibitory orders are currently in force in parts of central Delhi, restricting assemblies and processions.

Speaking about recent

denials of permissions, the officer said requests had been denied for an August 21 demonstration called by Reservation Hatao Andolan and subsequent requests for an All India Students’ Association-led stir over “lapses” in the SIR.

“In each case where the organisers went ahead with the stir despite the prohibition, they were detained,” the officer said.

Several attempted marches and demonstrations around Jantar Mantar since October 2 have also led to detentions, the officer added.



Police personnel stationed near Jantar Mantar on Wednesday. ANI

Consider plea for ‘always-on’ body cameras: HC to Centre

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked the Centre to consider a representation seeking standard operating procedures for the use of ‘always-on’ body-worn cameras by police and Rapid Action Force personnel during crowd-control and protest-management duties.

The court asked the government to communicate its decision within six months while disposing of the public interest litigation. The plea also sought rules governing the storage, retention and use of footage recorded through such cameras.

INDIA bloc, AAP protest outside CEO’s Office

Cong. Delhi chief questions AAP’s ‘change of heart’ on joining stir called by Oppn. alliance; have always backed well-meaning protests, says Bharadwaj

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Delhi unit of the INDIA bloc staged a demonstration outside the office of Delhi Chief Electoral Officer Ashok Kumar in Kashmere Gate on Wednesday, making it a new flashpoint for protests over alleged irregularities in the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which is not part of the alliance, also joined the protest. AAP Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj said the party had participated following a call by the Left parties for a wider alliance to “save democracy”.

The gate to the CEO’s Office in Old St. Stephen’s



Members of the Oppn. alliance and AAP protesting outside the Delhi CEO’s office in Kashmere Gate on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA/ANI

College Building was cordoned off with barricades amid heavy police deployment to prevent the protesters from entering the premises. The protesters demanded the SIR exercise

be scrapped, names of all eligible voters excluded from the draft roll be restored and elections be held using ballot papers.

The State units of the Congress, Rashtriya Janata



Dal, Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CP(M)], among others, participated in the demonstration.

In Delhi, around 47.5 lakh names were left out of

the draft roll published on August 31.

Earlier in the day, Delhi Congress unit chief Deven-der Yadav questioned Mr. Bharadwaj’s “change of heart” after AAP an-

nounced its support to the INDIA bloc protests. “You didn’t attend the INDIA meeting, nor did you show up for yesterday’s [Tuesday] historic rally. Seeing the public’s enthusiasm yesterday and their support for [Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha] Rahul Gandhiji and [Wayanad MP] Priyanka Gandhiji suddenly make you remember INDIA?” he said.

In response, Mr. Bharadwaj said his party had joined the call issued by the Left parties and that AAP and its students’ wing had participated in all protest calls since October 2.

“We support all well-meaning protests, be it the protests by farmers, women wrestlers, the CJP and now this,” he said.

Gymkhana Club eviction case: HC judge recuses self

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi High Court judge Justice Prateek Jalan on Wednesday recused himself from hearing a case concerning the Centre’s proceedings to evict the Delhi Gymkhana Club from its 27.3-acre premises on Sardarjung Road.

Justice Jalan directed that the lawsuit by the Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd. Staff Welfare Association be listed before another Bench on Friday. “I am going to recuse from this matter. There are matters where one does not trust one’s own judgement. There is too much personal involved,” he said.

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SAMARTH BHUTANI, Advocate
1625, AB, SECOND FLOOR, TILAK NAGAR NEW DELHI - 110 018

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For more details and participation in the above e-tender, please visit the website <https://www.intenders.gov.in/>. Last date for online submission of duly filled tender documents is 27.10.2026 on or before 3 PM. TICEL Bio Park Ltd reserves the right to accept/reject any one / all tenders without assigning any reason.
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Letter No. : 1691 / Nivida / 94

Dated: 07.10.2026

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online e-tenders for execution of "Supply & Installation of Flap Gate including all other appurtenant work at Hindon River outfall on bypass pipeline of 245 MLD WTP under O&M of 100 Cusec Gangajal Water Supply Scheme, Siddharth Vihar, Ghaziabad". Bids are invited in two bid system on percentage rate basis from eligible reputed and experienced bidders. E-tender documents will be available for download from **12.10.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.** Pre-Bid meeting will be held on **dated 21.10.2026 at 13:00 Hrs.** in the office of under signed. E-bid can be submitted till **26.10.2026 up to 13:00 Hrs.** and technical bid shall be opened on **26.10.2026 at 16:00 Hrs.** in the office of The Executive Engineer, Gangajal Project Unit, U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban), Ghaziabad in presence of contractor or their authorized representative. E-tender Cost is **Rs. 3000.00+GST @18%**. Details are available on U.P. Govt. e-procurement portal <http://etender.up.nic.in> & U.P. Jal Nigam (Urban) website www.jn.upscd.gov.in.

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Gurmeet Singh S/O Bajaj Singh R/O 239 Preet Nagar, Diagiana, Jammu is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 197/2016 U/S 48 Excise Act of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced / still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Gurmeet Singh

S/O : Bajaj Singh

Address : 239 Preet Nagar, Diagiana, Jammu

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578

2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949

4. SP City South : 0191-2430002

5. SDPO City East : 01912433778

6. P/S Bahu Fort : 0191-2475133

Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J-11896/26 Oct 06 2026

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
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Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Ganesh Kumar S/O Sukh Sagar R/O Pehrit Chattisgarh A/P Sec. No. 03 Channi Himmat, Jammu, Near Bagga Mandi is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 256/2017 U/S 457/380/201 RPC of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced / still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Ganesh Kumar

S/O : Sukh Sagar

Address : Pehrit Chattisgarh A/P Sec. No. 03 Channi Himmat, Jammu, Near Bagga Mandi

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578

2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949

4. SP City South : 0191-2430002

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6. P/S Bahu Fort : 0191-2475133

Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J-11836/26 Oct 06 2026

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Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Qamar Din S/O Sattar R/O Bharnasal Tehsil Morhe District Reasiis evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 38/2023 U/S 307 IPC, 3/4/5 ESA, 16/18 UA(P) Acttof P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced / still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Qamar Din

S/O : Sattar

Address : Bharnasal TehsilMorhe District Reasi

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578

2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949

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Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J-11843/26 Oct 06 2026

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Jaffer Iqbal S/O Bhader Hussain R/O Gurdaswala Tehsil Thanamandi , District Rajouri is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 171/2016 U/S 279/304-A RPC of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids / efforts the accused could not be traced / still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name : Jaffer Iqbal

S/O : Bhader Hussain

Address : Gurdaswala Tehsil Thanamandi , District Rajouri

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578

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Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J-11844/26 Oct 06 2026

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NIT No. 17/LINEN/MPB/2026 Dated: 06/10/2026

TENDER NOTICE 2nd Call

Online tender for Annual Supply of Linen Items in State Guest Houses of Government of Madhya Pradesh at New Delhi, namely, Madhya Pradesh Bhawan, 29, C-D, Jesus & Mary Marg, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi- 110021 are invited with two bid system (Technical bid & Financial bid) through e-Tendering website (www.mptenders.gov.in) or www.mpbhawanbooking.mp.gov.in in the prescribed proforma from registered contractors in CPWD/ State PWD / DDA / NDMC / MCD and reputed firms.

S. No	Description of Items	Remarks
10.	NIT No. & Date	NIT No. 17/LINEN/MPB/2026 Dated 06/10/2026
11.	Issuance of tender	M.P. Bhawan, New Delhi website (www.mptenders.gov.in) or www.mpbhawanbooking.mp.gov.in
12.	Pre-bid conference	21/10/2026 at 03:00 PM in the conference hall of Madhya Pradesh Bhawan, Plot No. 29 C-D, Jesus Mary Marg, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi -110021
13.	Date of Submission of tender	Submission on or before 27/10/2026 up to 03:00 PM
14.	Date of Opening of technical bid	28/10/2026 at 03:00 PM
15.	Date of opening of financial bid	04/11/2026 at 03:00 PM
16.	Probable Amount of Contract	Rs. 23,00,000/-
17.	Cost of Tender cost	Rs. 1500/- (to be paid online)
18.	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Rs. 69,000/- (to be paid online)

Addl. Resident Commissioner M.P. Bhawan, New Delhi

G19654 / 26

CPI(M) seeks relief for Assam flood victims

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Less than a week after Rajor Dal president and MLA Akhil Gogoi began his indefinite hunger strike demanding immediate financial assistance to the flood-affected families, members of the Communist Party of India (Marxist), or CPI(M), organised a protest rally on Wednesday to press for a similar demand.

According to Nirankush Nath, the CPI(M)'s State secretariat member, more than 2,000 protesters were detained following scuffles

with police personnel during their thwarted march to Dispur.

The protesters demanded immediate relief and rehabilitation for the flood-affected people of eastern Assam, particularly in Charaideo and Sivasagar districts, and a judicial inquiry into the causes of the devastating flood.

The other demands included the formation of a North East Flood Management Authority, recognition of floods and erosion in Assam as a national problem, and the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

CJI to attend NLSIU convocation on Oct. 17

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant will preside over the 34th annual convocation of National Law School of India University (NLSIU) on October 17, while actor and multilingual theatre artist Arundathi Nag will be the chief guest.

On August 27, the NLSIU administration announced the cancellation of convocation, originally scheduled on September 12, due to "unavoidable circumstances" and students could collect the degrees in absentia

after 700 students signed a letter addressed to the Vice-Chancellor opposing the participation of CJI Surya Kant and Bar Council of India chairman Manan Kumar Mishra. NLSIU students had come in support of National Academy of Legal Studies and Research (NALSAR) students and opposed the statement issued by Mr. Mishra against them. The development came after NALSAR students in Hyderabad opposed the presence of the CJI at their convocation citing his remarks on students against the NEET exam paper leak.

Timings
DELHI

THURSDAY, OCT. 08		
RISE	06:18	SET 17:59
MOON	RISE 03:50	SET 16:33
FRIDAY, OCT. 09		
RISE	06:18	SET 17:58
MOON	RISE 04:50	SET 17:03
SATURDAY, OCT. 10		
RISE	06:19	SET 17:57
MOON	RISE 05:49	SET 17:34

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Delhi police appeal to citizens not to join October 10 protest

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Amid heavy security deployment across the New Delhi district, Delhi Police has launched a localised outreach campaign to prevent public assembly for the October 10 Jantar Mantar protest led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) along with Left and youth organisations seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and the suspension of the special intensive revision (SIR) drive. The police have officially rejected permission for the protest.

Authorities are holding meetings with student paying guest owners, market associations, and Resident Welfare Associations to appeal to citizens not to join the agitation between October 7 and 10.

"A meeting was held

with district police officials and local citizens highlighting the importance of maintaining law and order," said Mohammad Shahid Gangohi, a social activist who attended the security briefing in Central Delhi's Chandni Mahal area.

The community leaders agreed to cooperate and advise residents against joining, Mr. Gangohi said. He added that local shops have been asked to close 30 minutes early, at 11.30 p.m. Mr. Gangohi said his own family has been impacted by the SIR drive as six of his sons' names were allegedly deleted from the electoral rolls.

CJP condemns curbs
Condemning the restrictions, CJP leader Saurav Das told *The Hindu*, "We have already informed the public that Delhi Police is planning to restrict the

protest, but authorities fail to realise that the youth of this country are now awakened."

"These intimidation tactics by Delhi Police will no longer work," the CJP leader added.

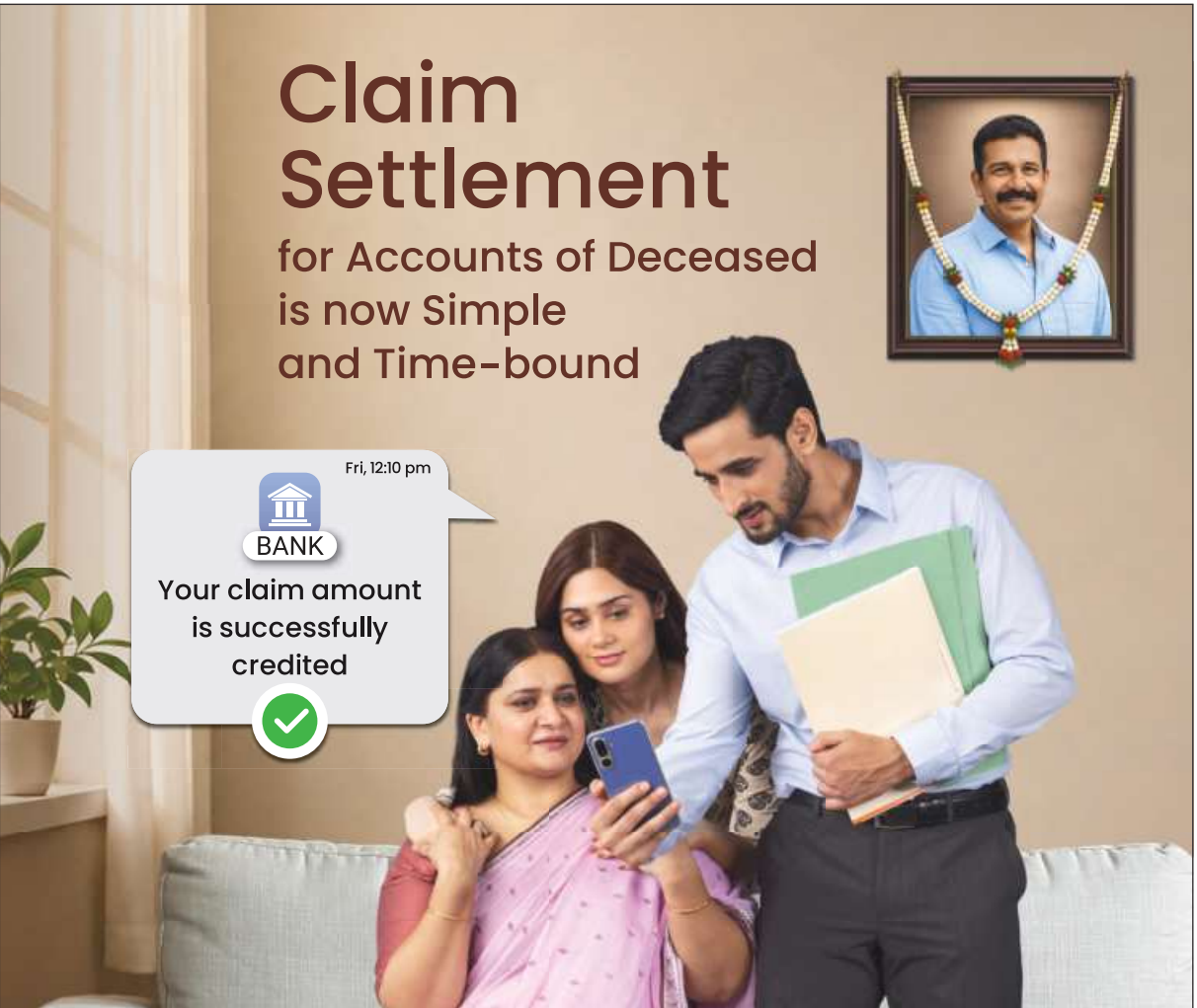
A senior police officer, speaking on the condition of anonymity, said that authorities are actively tracking individuals who participated in the previous demonstration. "Orders have been issued to monitor and, if necessary, pre-emptively detain past agitators under Sections 126 and 170 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita," the officer said.

Security agencies will deploy Facial Recognition System technology to monitor over 2,800 individuals with criminal antecedents who were flagged during the July protests.

(With inputs from Surchi Kumari)

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A ND-NDE

DAY 2 OF
DETOUR

High drama gripped Delhi again as an INDIA bloc lunch segued into a second day of protests led by Rahul Gandhi calling for the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar



Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra; party workers and supporters atop a bus; Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge; and a protester being detained. ANI/REUTERS



INBRIEF

Digvijaya Singh set to launch M.P.-Ayodhya yatra on Oct. 20

Terming alleged “vote chori” and “chanda chori” as major issues confronting the nation, Congress veteran leader and former Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Digvijaya Singh on Wednesday announced that he will embark on a yatra on October 20 to demand an impartial probe into them. Mr. Singh said his Satya Sanatan Swabhiman Yatra will start from Mahakal Temple in Ujjain, travel via Orchha in the central Madhya Pradesh and end at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya in adjoining Uttar Pradesh, covering a distance of around 850 km. The yatra will cover a distance of 15 km per day till it reaches its destination. PTI

Maharashtra CM meets Shah, seeks aid for drought-hit State

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Wednesday met Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi and sought special financial assistance from the Centre for the State, where nearly 80 per cent of the talukas have been affected by severe drought. During the meeting, Mr. Shah assured him that the Centre would provide maximum possible drought assistance to Maharashtra, Mr. Fadnavis said. Talking to reporters later in the national capital, Mr. Fadnavis said he handed over to Mr. Shah a copy of the State’s advance proposal seeking assistance and requested an immediate visit by a central team to assess the situation on the ground. PTI

SIR: special camps to restore names left out of Bengal rolls

State CEO puts up on website list of deletions under ASDD category; Mamata-led TMC faction MP Sagarika Ghose questions move after many people were denied right to vote during Assembly poll

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Special camps will be held to ensure that any eligible voter whose name was deleted during the special intensive revision (SIR) under the absent, shifted, dead or duplicate (ASDD) category is put back on the electoral rolls through Form 6, Additional Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of West Bengal Arindam Niyogi told *The Hindu* on Wednesday.

A few of these camps have already started operating in Hooghly’s Chanditala, Tarakeshwar and Chandannagar, he added.

Over 58 lakh names, marked under the ASDD category, were left out of the draft roll published in December 2025.

The statement came a day after CEO Neelam Meena issued a notice stating that eligible voters left out



A special camp to accept Form 6 applications from new voters and those left out of the roll, in Hooghly on Wednesday. X/@CEOWESTBENGAL

of the voter list can apply for restoration of their name through Form 6. The notice also asked new voters in the State, any person above 18 years, to register and enroll their names in the voter list.

“For the left out eligible voter, the list of ASDD voters of SIR 2026 is available at the link ceowestbengal.wb.gov.in/asdsir and also at the respective links on the websites of the District Elec-

toral Officers. Any person in this list may submit Form 6 online or through the Booth Level Officers for inclusion of his/her name in the electoral roll,” it stated.

Mr. Niyogi also clarified that it is “complete misinformation” that people need to be mapped with the 2002 voter list when they are filling Form 6. “No new voter has to be mapped,” he said. Meanwhile, Mamata All

India Trinamool Congress MP Sagarika Ghose criticised the move. “First, leave out LAKHS of eligible voters BEFORE the elections [2026 Assembly poll]. Ensure @BJP4India wins elections at all costs. Next, offer to add deleted voters AFTER the elections (after @BJP4India has won ILLEGALLY),” she wrote on X.

The CEO put up a post countering the claims and termed them “misleading”. Former State CEO Jawhar Sircar said the notice was a clear “admission of guilt” that there were “wrongful” deletions during the SIR.

Awaiting clarity

However, there is no clarity on whether the option to fill Form 6 to get reinstated in the voter roll is available to 27 lakh people whose names were deleted from the final electoral roll after the adjudication process found them “ineligible”.

BJD backtracks on INDIA bloc’s Odisha bandh call for today

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

For the second consecutive day, the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) on Wednesday issued a clarification asserting that it maintains equidistance from both the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress.

The principal Opposition party in Odisha found itself on a sticky wicket after Pramila Mallik, its chief whip in the Assembly, said on Wednesday that as part of the INDIA bloc, the party supported the latter’s ‘Odisha Bandh’ called for today. Within an hour, however, she backtracked, saying the BJD was not part of any alliance and hence did not support the proposed strike.

The regional party had issued a similar clarification on Tuesday after its Rajya Sabha MPs participated in a protest march organised by the INDIA bloc in New Delhi demanding the resignation of Chief

Pramila Mallik, the party’s chief whip in the Assembly, said on Wednesday that as part of the INDIA bloc, BJD supported the ‘Odisha Bandh’, but changed her stance in an hour

Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

“BJD neither supports nor opposes the bandh called for tomorrow. We have maintained an independent and principled position. Our focus is on the rights and interests of the people of Odisha,” party spokesperson Lenin Mohanty said.

‘Aligning with BJP’

Senior Congress leader Santosh Singh Saluja ridiculed the BJD’s change of stance within hours. “BJD is a directionless party. It has a habit of aligning with the BJP,” he said.

SBI software prevents Christian applicants from selecting ‘ST option’, alleges Arunachal forum

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Arunachal Christian Forum (ACF), an apex body of Christians in Arunachal Pradesh, has alleged that the State Bank of India’s (SBI) digital banking software prevents followers of the religion from selecting the ‘Scheduled Tribe (ST)’ option while opening an account or updating their KYC (know your customer) details.

The ACF said the digital system automatically classifies an applicant as ‘general’ upon selecting Christianity as their faith.

In a letter to the regional manager of the SBI’s office in Itanagar, the State’s capital, ACF president James Techhi Tara and secretary general Yomrik Lombi

The ACF said the software disables the ST option when an applicant selects Christian as their religion and warned of agitations if the issue is not rectified

warned of agitations if the public sector bank did not make the requisite technical corrections within 15 days. The SBI’s regional office received the letter on October 5.

The ACF said the software disables the ST option when an applicant selects Christian as their religion. Pointing out that tribal status in Arunachal Pradesh was not contingent on religious affiliation under the Constitution

(Scheduled Tribes) Order of 1950, the forum said the software was “potentially discriminatory”.

“The SBI is not the competent authority to de-list a tribal Christian customer who possesses a valid ST certificate. The bank cannot automatically classify a tribal Christian under the general category solely based on their declared religion,” the ACF letter stated. The forum urged SBI authorities to examine the on-boarding logic, clarify whether any regulatory or Reserve Bank of India directive permits such classification and rectify the software to prevent religion and tribal status from being treated as mutually exclusive. In response, SBI officials said they were looking into the matter.

Organisations engaged in religious conversion shall be denied FCRA registration: Madras HC

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has said religious organisations engaged in conversions shall be denied Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) registration, and that only organisations whose activities do not affect the nation’s secular fabric and social amity are entitled to registration.

The court was hearing a Civil Miscellaneous Appeal filed by Kanzeon Public Charitable Trust – founded by a Christian priest in Kodaikanal – after its application for registration under the FCRA was rejected.

The appellant said the trust had established a Zen Meditation Centre at Kodaikanal and that its activities could not be labelled as religious. The centre contended that the govern-



We are a pluralist nation. Unlike the USA, we are not a melting pot but a salad bowl, a beautiful metaphor credited to Justice Ruma Pal. This status quo would be upset if one religious group gains ascendancy

ment’s policy was to check the inflow of foreign funds that might be used for conversion and other activities detrimental to the country’s secular fabric.

The Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and M.D. Sumathi said, “One cannot forget the fact that Christianity is a messianic religion. Their theological and religious mis-

sion is to bring everyone within the fold of Jesus Christ. There is a saying ‘a leopard will not change its spots’. Unlike Hinduism, which is inclusive, the Abrahamic religions are inherently exclusive.”

Rule 9 of the FCRA Rules, 2011, states that the application must be in Form FC-3A. Form FC-3A requires the applicant to disclose the nature of the organisation.

“The appellant trust claims to subscribe to Zen Buddhist philosophy. On its own showing, the appellant is a religious organisation. The authority rightly states that Zen Buddhism is a variant of the Mahayana Buddhist School. Every Buddhist school will come under the broad umbrella of Buddhism. Zen can be no exception. Since the appellant’s application did not correctly identify its

nature as religious, the application was rightly negatived,” the court said.

The judges said the appellant need not have been so coy. Section 12 of the FCRA bars only an unregistered religious organisation from accepting foreign contributions. An organisation having a definite religious programme is entitled to apply for a certificate of registration from the Central government under Sections 11 and 12 of the Act.

“We are a pluralist nation. Unlike the USA, we are not a melting pot but a salad bowl, a beautiful metaphor credited to Justice Ruma Pal. This status quo would be upset if one religious group gains ascendancy,” the court said, adding, “One cannot keep any card up one’s sleeve. This is no game of hide and seek.”



Former Nagaland Chief Minister S.C. Jamir PTI

NSCN leaders withdraw remarks on ex-CM Jamir

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Two senior leaders of the National Socialist Council of Nagalim (NSCN) have retracted their September 16 statement on former Nagaland Chief Minister S.C. Jamir after he met Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat.

V.S. Atem, the NSCN’s Deputy Ato Kilonser (Prime Minister), and R.H. Raising, a member of the group’s Steering Committee, withdrew their views in a joint statement issued on Tuesday. The retraction followed a 15-day deadline set by the Ao Senden, the top body of the Ao Nagas, for them to withdraw their views on Mr. Jamir.

“If our comments on S.C. Jamir have hurt the sentiment of the Ao Senden, it was never meant to do so and therefore, we do retract it forthright,” the two NSCN leaders said.

A five-time Chief Minister, Mr. Jamir belongs to the Ao community. He met Mr. Bhagwat in New Delhi on September 10 and urged him to press the Centre for an early political settlement of the Naga peace process. Six days later, the two NSCN leaders questioned Mr. Jamir’s authority to speak on the issue, asserting that he was “not an advocate of the Naga people”.

‘Coordination with CJP on agenda basis, but alliances are always on radar’

INTERVIEW

Neha Bora

Ashna Butani

In the run-up to a collective protest on October 10 seeking the scrapping of the special intensive revision of electoral rolls and the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the All India Students’ Association (AISA) and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) have been coordinating despite differences in their ideologies and approaches. In an interview with

The Hindu, AISA national president Neha Bora speaks about the ties between the two organisations, their differences and the scope for a broader alliance. Edited excerpts:

In response to comparisons between you and [Abhijeet] Dipke as leaders, you said the idea is solidarity instead of comparison. What do these collaborations look like on the ground, and is a larger alliance on the radar?

AISA and CJP are two very different kinds of groups. Our understanding is not the same; our ideology is

not the same. We are very clearly a Left, radical-Left student movement, while they are still figuring out what they want to be, as they say. So, this coordination that we have with them is on an agenda basis. A common agenda on common ground – that is the extent of our coordination. And, of course, we have a working relationship with the spokespersons because we shared such a long movement at Jantar Mantar [in July].

For us, alliances are always on the radar. And I appreciate that they are always on the radar because, at different points in time, people do feel comfortable



reaching out to one another. We also reached out to CJP when we gave the call for the October 2 protest and said that since they had called for a protest in Mumbai, those who could not travel to Mumbai could be asked to join us here at Jantar Mantar. We have been reaching out to the

NSUI (National Students’ Union of India) and IYC (Indian Youth Congress).

There is scope to come together, and we are always ready to serve as mediators or do whatever is required for this larger unity to happen.

What is the idea behind the October 10 protest? The point is to take back everything they have laid siege to, beginning with Jantar Mantar, which, on paper, is a designated protest site but has been made completely inaccessible to the people. And, of course, why are we trying to reclaim our right to protest? To hold the Election Com-

mission of India (ECI) accountable. So, that’s the game plan; we keep coming back till Gyanesh Kumar is held to account.

With roadblocks such as the area being cordoned off, how difficult is it to mobilise people, especially those affected by the issue? It’s very difficult because a major section of the people whose names have been struck off are poor, working-class people.

Now, the point is also to reach out to people in areas like Okhla, Jamia Nagar and Mangolpuri, where so many people have been struck off the rolls. Over

the next few days, we will probably organise programmes there to mobilise them for the October 10 protest.

And how do you see this generation’s response to everything through humour and trends? When they [the government] try to create fear, where neither the police nor the judiciary upholds the law, what do you have as a citizen? You have nothing. So then, are people expected to sit, live in fear and never speak out or step out of their houses? No. And it is in such moments that we use humour and satire.

INBRIEF



Keralam, NTPC to set up new facility to tackle power crisis

The Keralam government will establish a 2,000 megawatt hour (MWh) battery energy storage system (BESS) at Kayamkulam in Alappuzha district in collaboration with NTPC Ltd, as part of efforts to address the electricity shortage faced by the State, according to Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan. It was also decided at the meeting to speed up work on a 27-MW solar power project implemented by NTPC at Kayamkulam. NTPC Ltd has also agreed to supply 300 MW to Keralam from the NTPC project in Maharashtra.

Shivakumar warns Ministers against 'sting operations'

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar is learnt to have warned his Cabinet colleagues to remain vigilant against possible sting operations, amid reports that private agencies could be secretly recording Ministers' conversations, meetings, and movements. Deputy Chief Minister G. Parameshwara and Minister H.C. Balakrishna confirmed that Mr. Shivakumar, who also holds the Intelligence portfolio, had alerted the Ministers about "sting operations".

Karnataka signals intent to review Cauvery allocation citing Indus Waters Treaty

State's response in SC comes on Tamil Nadu's complaint of backlog in water release; Karnataka refers to international practice to revisit inter-State water allocations in 'changed circumstances'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Karnataka on Wednesday signalled its intent in the Supreme Court to unravel the decades-old judicial consensus on the Cauvery water-sharing dispute on the grounds of "inequitable allocation" of water and "changed circumstances".

Even the Union of India has been seeking a modification of the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty – now in abeyance – on the ground of changed circumstances, the State said. Karnataka was replying to Tamil Nadu's application in the Supreme Court, complaining of backlog in the allocation of the Cauvery water.

The State's response, filed by advocate Nishanth Patil and settled by senior advocate Mohan Katarki, referred to international practices to revisit inter-State water allocations by agreement or adjudication in the changed circum-



River of contention: Karnataka says the Cauvery water allocation norms set by the tribunal follow a rigid pattern. K. MURALI KUMAR

stances, known as *rebus sic stantibus*.

"In view of the looming inequity, the State of Karnataka reserves its right to apply in the changed circumstances for reopening of the inequitable allocation in the Award of Tribunal read with judgment of the Supreme Court. The normal practice is that the water allocations are periodically revisited," the 40-page reply said.

The tribunal award, along with the Supreme Court judgment in 2018, had allocated the total annual flow of the Cauvery basin assessed at 740 tmc ft (thousand million cubic feet) at 50% dependability at Lower Coleroon Anicut. This water was apportioned between Karnataka (284.75 tmc ft), Tamil Nadu (404.25 tmc ft), Keralam (30 tmc ft), and Puducherry (7 tmc ft), alongside allo-

State's monsoon rain was second lowest in 70 years

BENGALURU

The rainfall received by Karnataka during this southwest monsoon was the second lowest in the last 70 years (after 1956), show data. As against the normal rainfall of 852 mm for the southwest monsoon period from June to September, the State received only 551 mm this year, reporting a shortage of 35%.

cations of 10 tmc ft for environmental flows and 4 tmc ft earmarked as inevitable wastage into the sea.

In case the annual yield was less than 740 tmc ft in any water year due to distress caused by less rainfall, the States were directed to share distress proportionately (*pro rata*). But Karnataka said there was no scientific formula for sharing distress on a *pro rata* manner.

Odisha govt. constitutes panel to study political backwardness of SEBCs

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha government on Wednesday formed a panel to study the numerical strength, political representation and extent of political backwardness among the socially and educationally backward classes (SEBCs) in local self-government institutions.

Retired Odisha High Court judge Justice Pramath Patnaik will head the panel, according to a notification issued by the ST and SC Development, Minorities and Backward Classes Welfare Department.

Retired IAS officer Bijay Kumar Prusty will serve as a member and Sujata Mishra, Special Secretary in the department, will be the member-secretary of the commission, it stated.

The decision assumes significance as both panchayat and urban local body elections are scheduled to be held next year.

The commission will study the proportion of SEBCs in various local self-government institutions in both rural and urban areas of the State in relation to the total population of the respective areas. It will also

The decision assumes significance as both rural and urban local body polls are set to be held next year

examine their political representation and the nature and implications of their political backwardness in comparison with their population, read a statement issued by the Chief Minister's Office.

"The exercise will facilitate appropriate measures to ensure adequate representation of people belonging to SEBCs in local self-government institutions," the statement added.

The Bharatiya Janata Party government had earlier decided to provide 11.25% reservation for students belonging to this category in professional higher educational institutions.

The Naveen Patnaik-led former Biju Janata Dal government had constituted the State Commission for Backward Classes in 2023 for surveying the social and educational conditions of the people belonging to the backward classes. The commission had put the State's OBC population at 1.95 crore.

A.P. clears decks for foreign varsity campuses

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh Cabinet on Wednesday approved amendments to the Andhra Pradesh Education Act, 1982, and a new policy for 2026 to facilitate the es-

tablishment of campuses of foreign higher educational institutions and private universities in the State. It also approved a Centre of Excellence for tribal students at Marikavallasa in Visakhapatnam, offering intensive residential

coaching for IIT-JEE and NEET examinations.

It approved reclassification of 1.69 acres for a guesthouse for officials of the Kuppam Area Development Authority and ratified orders for regularisation of encroachments.

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबंधक यूनिट-31, कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, (उ०प्र० सरकार का उपक्रम) एस०बी०-९०, शास्त्री नगर, गाजियाबाद-201002 निविदा सूचना सं.: 1801/Vividh-12/321 दिनांक : 07-10-2026 ई-निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम की ओर से Construction of Office Building For Government Livestock And Agriculture Farms Babugarh Distt Hapur, अनुमानित लागत रू० 78.90 लाख (जीएफएडी० रू० सहित एवं लेबर सेस सहित) हेतु सी०एण्ड डी०एस० में यथोचित श्रेणी में भवन कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 04.11.2026 के अग्रान्ह 16.00 बजे तक अल्पकालीन ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 08.10.2026 से दिनांक 04.11.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 04.11.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 16.30 बजे सी०एण्ड डी०एस० यूनिट-31, उ०प्र० जल निगम, गाजियाबाद में निविदा खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रू० 5000.00 + GST (18%) अनिवार्य देय होगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्योरमेंट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका पृथक से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LTD.
(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking) Victoria Cross Vijayta Gabar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanwalli Road, Dehradun -248001 Corporate Identity No. U40109UR2011SGC025867/2358 Telephone- (0135)-2763672-76, Fax: (0135)-2760289

E-TENDER DATE EXTENSION NOTICE
E-tender Specification No. CCP-I/28/2026-2027 invited by this office for supply of LT XLPE Al. Cable 1x70Sq.mm, LT XLPE Al. Cable 1x120Sq.mm, LT XLPE Al. Cable 1x240Sq.mm & LT XLPE Al. Cable 1x630Sq.mm are hereby extended due to unavoidable reasons. The e-tender can be purchased and submitted upto 17:00 hrs of 13.10.2026. Part-I of the e-tender shall be opened on 14.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs.
Other terms & conditions will remain same as per original tender notice. For further details, please visit our website www.uktenders.gov.in
No. : 811/EE(CM)/JUPCL /A-2 **Superintending Engineer Corporate (C & P-I)**
Date : 07.10.2026
"SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION". Use LED Bulb, Save Electricity (Toll Free No. 1912) "Pay Electricity Bill Online 24 x 7 from www.upsl.org." (For information on Electricity theft, Informer may report to Toll Free No. 1800 180 4185 / Fax No 0135-2760911)

HARYANA POWER GENERATION CORPORATION LIMITED
RAJIV GANDHI THERMAL POWER PLANT, KHEDAR, HISAR
(A Unit of Haryana Power Generation Corporation Limited)

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
For Long-Term Sale of Dry Fly Ash through Auction and Linked Utilisation of Pond Ash from RGTPP, Khedar
Memo No. Ch-07/XEN/CMD-II(DFA)/2026-27/RGTPP-F-29 **Dated: 07.10.2026**
RGTPP, HPGCL proposes to explore a long-term arrangement for sale of Dry Fly Ash (DFA) through a transparent auction process. This EOI is being issued to obtain market inputs from cement manufacturers and fly ash / ash-based product manufacturers regarding the annual DFA quantity they can lift, the preferred tenure of the long-term arrangement and the indicative rate at which they would be willing to purchase DFA.
HPGCL is also planning to link utilisation of Pond Ash with the long-term DFA arrangement. The agency lifting DFA may also be offered Pond Ash (optional) from the RGTPP ash dyke on requirement basis and on an "as is where is" basis, subject to availability and applicable statutory requirements. Excavation / loading and transportation of Pond Ash shall be in the scope of the agency. The agency is requested to indicate the quantity of Pond Ash proposed to be lifted and whether it is willing to lift the same on chargeable basis, free of cost, or against some incentive in the form of rebate in the applicable DFA rate.
Interested agencies may visit the official website of HPGCL at <https://hpgcl.org.in> for detailed information regarding the EOI, including the prescribed format for furnishing the required information and the important terms and conditions. The interested agencies shall submit their offers in the prescribed format as per the following details:-

Last Date & Time for Submission	7 days from date of issue of EOI
Mode of Submission	By e-mail and/or sealed hard copy
Submission / Contact	Executive Engineer/CMD-II, RGTPP, HPGCL, Khedar, Hisar

-----sd-----
Executive Engineer/CMD-II, For Chief Engineer/RGTPP, HPGCL, Khedar, Hisar.
1187/11/38/2027/50007/C/199/7

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, RURAL WORKS CIRCLE : SUNDARAGADA
AT/PO-SANKARA, SUNDARGARH-770020, E-mail address-serw_sundargarh@yahoo.com

No.Tender Online – RWCCESNG-31 of 2026-27, Letter No.5474/ Dtd.05.10.2026
e-Procurement NOTICE

1. Type of the Work : Bridge Work (SBY)
2. Class of Contractor : As specified in the column-6 of the Annexure
3. Time of Completion : As specified in the column-5 of the Annexure
4. Detail Projects : As per Annexure attached
5. Estimated Cost : As specified in the column-4 of the Annexure
6. Other details:

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for Bidding From To	Last Date & Time of Seeking Tender Clarification	Date & Time of Opening of tender Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Sundaragada	RWCCESNG-31 of 2026-27	09.10.2026 11:00 AM 26.10.2026 5:00 PM	23.10.2026 5:00 PM	27.10.2026 11:00 AM	Will be intimated separately

● Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersodisha.gov.in
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Sundaragada.
25001/12792627 OIPR-25001/25133/11/26-27/0048

GOVERNMENT OF HIMACHAL PRADESH
DEPARTMENT OF MPP & POWER
GLOBAL INVITATION OF BIDS FOR IMPLEMENTATION OF HYDRO ELECTRIC PROJECTS IN HIMACHAL PRADESH
2nd CORRIGENDUM OF NOTICE INVITING PROPOSALS
In partial modification of Notice Inviting Proposals (NIP) & 1st corrigendum for implementation of 27 Hydro Electric Projects (HEPs) upto 25 MW having total capacity of 300.9 MW published on 11.07.2026 & 06.09.2026, which is also uploaded in the Directorate of Energy website i.e. <https://doe.hp.gov.in/>, it is to inform that the last date of sale of Bid Documents, last date of submission of Bids and the date of opening of Bids are hereby extended as under:-
Last date for sale of Bid Documents : 27.10.2026 upto 1700 Hours
Tentative date of Pre-Bid Conference : 03.11.2026
Last date of submission of Bids : 17.11.2026 upto 1300 Hours (IST)
Date of opening of Bids : 17.11.2026 at 1500 Hours (IST) onwards
Note:-If the Last date for submission of Bids or the date of opening of bids happens to be a holiday declared by the Government of Himachal Pradesh in Shimla, the Bids will be submitted and opened on the next working day in the same order and at the same time.
Payment of Bid Document Cost through RTGS/Online Banking:
Interested bidders may also purchase the Bid Document by making payment of the prescribed Bid Document cost through Online Banking/RTGS in the following bank account:
Account Number:- 54140100000922
Bank:- Bank of Baroda
IFSC:- BARB0NWSIM (Fifth character is zero)
Branch Name:- NEWSIM, Himachal Pradesh
MICR Code:- 171012004
Account Name:- Chief Engineer Directorate of Energy, New Shimla
All other terms and conditions of the Notice Inviting Proposals published on 11.07.2026 shall remain unchanged.
For & on behalf of the Governor of HP
-Sd-
Director (Energy), Directorate of Energy, Govt. of HP,
Tel. +91-177-2673552, Fax +91-1772673553
e-mail: ceenergy09@gmail.com
HP / 1055/2026-2027

Government of Karnataka
DIRECTORATE OF URBAN LAND TRANSPORT
URBAN DEVELOPMENT DEPARTMENT
OFFICE OF THE COMMISSIONER URBAN LAND TRANSPORT
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Website: <https://dult.karnataka.gov.in>
No:DULT/17/2026 **Dated : 07.10.2026**

TENDER NOTIFICATION
Directorate of Urban Land Transport (DULT) invites E-bids from the qualified consultancies for conducting **Techno-Economic Feasibility Study for Transitioning from BRTS to Modern TRAM System between Hubballi-Dharwad**. The last date for the receipt of e-bid on the KPPP portal for the tender is 17.11.2026, 17:30:00 PM. The bidders may download the tender document for from <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> web portal.
Tender Number is as follows

S.No	Tender Name	Tender No.
1	Techno-Economic Feasibility Study for Transitioning from BRTS to Rail-track based Modern TRAM System between Hubballi-Dharwad	DULT/2026-27/SE0053

Sd/- Joint Director(Admin)/(I/c) Directorate of Urban Land Transport Urban Development Department
DIPR/CP/3130/Shirdi Sai/2026-27

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar-751001
HE-SCH-PLAN-0032-2026/53907 /HE., Bhubaneswar, Dated:07.10.2026

Corrigendum-I
NOTICE INVITING RFP FOR PROCUREMENT, SUPPLY, INSTALLATION & COMMISSIONING OF LABORATORY EQUIPMENT & ITS ACCESSORIES FOR 5 STATE PUBLIC UNIVERSITIES UNDER REGIONAL DIRECTORATE OF EDUCATION, SAMBALPUR APPROVED UNDER PM-USHA.
RFP No. PM-USHA : 06/2026 Date: 18.09.2026

Sl. No.	RFP Cl. No.	Page No.	Description as per RFP	Now Modified Provisions
1	DATA SHEET (Sl. No.7 & 8)	4	Last Date & Time for Submission of Bid - 09/10/2026 (till 4:00 PM) (Registered Post & Speed Post only)	Last Date & Time for Submission of Bid - 02/11/2026 (till 4:00 PM) (Registered Post & Speed Post only)
2		4	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 13/10/2026 at 4:00 PM	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 03/11/2026 at 4:00 PM

All other terms and conditions of the RFP remain unchanged.
Joint Secretary to Govt. & SPD, RUSA / PM-USHA
11001/361/2627 OIPR-11001/11001/11/26-27/0069

TIDCO
TAMILNADU INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED (TIDCO)
CIN-U65933TN1965SGC005327

NOTICE NO. TIDCO/SPCFC-Sivakasi/2026-27 **Date: 08.10.2026**
Tamilnadu Industrial Development Corporation Ltd (TIDCO) intends to select a consulting firm for Preparation of Detailed Project Report (DPR) for establishing the Sivakasi Pyrotechnic Common Facility Centre (SPCFC) at Sivakasi in Virudhunagar District in accordance with the Terms of Reference as set out in the Request for Proposal document.
Interested Consultants can download the RFP from the website <https://tntenders.gov.in> and <https://tidco.com>.
The schedule for processing the Bids is as follows:-
1. Pre-bid meeting on 23-10-2026 at 03.00 PM at TIDCO Office, Egmore, Chennai.
2. Last date and time for Submission of Proposals is on or before 13-11-2026 at 03.00 PM through <https://tntenders.gov.in>.
3. Opening of Technical Proposals/Bids is at 5.00 p.m. on 13-11-2026 at TIDCO Office, Egmore, Chennai.
CHAIRMAN AND MANAGING DIRECTOR
Tamilnadu Industrial Development Corporation Ltd
19-A, Rukmini Lakshmiipathi Salai, Egmore, Chennai – 600 008
Ph: 044 – 2855 4421;
E-mail: cmd@tidco.com, vtndic@tidco.com; Website: <https://tidco.com>.
DIPR/ 3057 /Tender/2026

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar-751001
PT1-HE-SCH-POLICY-0003-2026/ 53895/HE., Bhubaneswar, Dated : 07.10.2026

Corrigendum-VII
NOTICE INVITING RFP FOR PROCUREMENT, SUPPLY, INSTALLATION & COMMISSIONING OF LABORATORY EQUIPMENT & ITS ACCESSORIES FOR BERHAMPUR UNIVERSITY, GANJAM UNDER REGIONAL DIRECTORATE OF EDUCATION, BERHAMPUR APPROVED UNDER PM-USHA.
RFP No. PM-USHA-02/2026 Date: 02.07.2026

Sl. No.	RFP Cl.No.	Page No.	Description as per RFP	Modified vide Corrigendum VI, dated 21.09.2026	Now Modified Provisions
1	DATA SHEET (Sl. No.7 & 8)	5	Last Date & Time for Submission of Bid - 23/07/2026 (till 4:00 PM) (Registered Post & Speed Post only)	Last Date & Time for Submission of Bid - 08/10/2026 (till 4:00 PM) (Registered Post & Speed Post only)	Last Date & Time for Submission of Bid - 30/10/2026 (till 4:00 PM) (Registered Post & Speed Post only)
2		6	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 24/07/2026 at 4:00 PM	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 09/10/2026 at 4:00 PM	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 31/10/2026 at 4:00 PM

All other terms and conditions of the RFP remain unchanged.
Joint Secretary to Govt. & SPD, RUSA/PM-USHA
11001/362/2627 OIPR-11001/11001/11/26-27/0070



Eyes on ice

Nobel tradition rewards individual talent in collective achievements

The Nobel Prize for physics to Francis Halzen recognises a clever idea: to use the Antarctic landmass to detect one of the universe’s most elusive particles. Halzen’s efforts helped create the IceCube observatory, which went on to detect high-energy particles from astronomical sources thousands to billions of light years away and transformed astronomy. Yet, the committee’s decision to award Halzen alone also perpetuates a deleterious tradition in how the institution has been recognising scientific achievement. The observatory consists of thousands of sensors embedded up to 2.5 kilometres beneath the South Pole, connected by cables to a laboratory aboveground. When subatomic particles called neutrinos interact with atoms in the ice, reactions lead to a small flash of light. Sensors detect and record it, allowing scientists to reconstruct the incoming neutrino’s energy and direction. Since coming online in 2011, IceCube has detected neutrinos of extremely high energy, giving scientists stronger clues about the crucibles in which these particles were created, and strengthening neutrino astronomy. The IceCube collaboration consists of over 400 experts from 14 countries, spanning astrophysics, engineering, and software development. Halzen’s leadership was necessary to create this entity.

However, the need to build IceCube at its scale should also have rendered the collective nature of its success impossible to ignore. The Nobel Foundation’s statutes prohibit dividing each prize among more than three individuals. So, in 2017 as well, the physics prize was awarded to three scientists for the detection of gravitational waves, which really required a collaboration of hundreds of researchers. The rules that govern prizes are human arrangements, and the Foundation’s choices are not explained away by its fealty to its traditions; in fact, its statutes allow prizes to be awarded to organisations as well – an option repeatedly overlooked. Every new science prize begins with distinguishing itself by identifying the ‘right’ laureates; the Nobel Prizes did so, too, until their accumulated prestige became so great that laureates were distinguished by receiving the prizes rather than distinguishing the prizes. Thus, even when the prize-giving committee follows an outdated model of scientific recognition, in the present instance by reinforcing the notion that exceptional scientific achievements can be cleanly attributed to exceptional individuals, it suffers minimal reputational damage. The institution is using its prestige – owed to the science it celebrates – to entrench a distorted understanding of how science works, more so at a time when scientific progress increasingly depends on extensive cooperation. No man is an island, least of all in science.

Past forward

Brazil might have missed an opportunity to leave the past behind

Flávio Bolsonaro, the eldest son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, took a surprise lead in the first round of Brazil’s presidential election on Sunday, bringing the far right, defeated four years ago and embroiled in legal battles ever since, back to the centre of the country’s politics. Most opinion polls had put President Luiz Inacio Lula da’Silva, the 80-year-old leftist President, in the lead. But Mr. Flávio, who ran a pro-business election campaign, appears to have mobilised the right-wing and centrist votes, winning 47% of the vote, while Mr. Lula, seeking a fourth term, finished second with 45%. The popular mood in Latin America’s biggest economy seems to be shifting to the right, reflecting a broader trend across the continent. Jair Bolsonaro, the former President, is serving a 27 year sentence in jail since 2025 for plotting a coup, in 2022, against Mr. Lula and has been barred from contesting elections. But his wife Michelle and another son Carlos have been elected to the Senate, while Jair Renan, his youngest son, will become a federal Congressman. While the Bolsonaro clan has made a political comeback with its Liberal Party doubling its representation in the Senate and cementing its position in the lower house, Mr. Lula’s Workers’ Party struggled to hold its ground.

Mr. Lula, who came back to active politics after his corruption convictions were annulled, beat Jair Bolsonaro in 2022, promising to rebuild Brazil’s social welfare system and economy and strengthen its democracy. He did relatively well in terms of macroeconomic indicators – Brazil recorded an average annual growth of 3% during 2023-25, and the annual unemployment rate fell from 6.6% in 2024 to 5.6% last year. His government raised spending and expanded welfare measures, which was a campaign promise to his core base. Real income rose and poverty fell. But three factors worked against him. First, Brazil’s fiscal situation became worse under Mr. Lula and interest rates rose, upsetting the middle class and businesses. Second, he faced criticism over his handling of organised crime, while Mr. Flávio offered a more headline approach. Third, Brazil’s conservative and evangelical sections, traditionally anti-left, rallied behind the Bolsonaro clan, mobilising right-wing support for Mr. Flávio, while many left-wing supporters, angry with mainstream politics, either abstained or cast invalid ballots. Mr. Lula’s camp accused the U.S. of electoral interference in favour of the Bolsonaros. As both candidates prepare for the October 25 run-off, Mr. Flávio may have an advantage as he and other right-wing candidates won more than 50% of the first round vote. Mr. Lula, will now have to persuade disillusioned voters on the left and appeal to the centrist swing votes to turn the tide. A tall ask, indeed.

Across the world, scientists, governments and communities are bringing plants and animals back from the brink of extinction. In India, a Great Indian Bustard chick has hatched in Kutch, Gujarat, after a decade, bringing fresh hope for this critically endangered bird. In Spain and Portugal, restoring habitat and prey, breeding lynx and returning them to the wild helped the Iberian lynx grow from 62 mature individuals in 2001 to 648 in 2022. The return of the scimitar-horned oryx to the wild in Chad, Africa, and the saiga antelope’s recovery in Kazakhstan offer further proof of what determined action can achieve. During Wildlife Week (October 2-8), we can celebrate these gains while asking what it will take to sustain them.

The Government of India’s Integrated Development of Wildlife Habitats scheme supports recovery action for 24 identified species and their habitats. States are mandated to undertake research, habitat improvement, protection and community participation. The species span India’s landscapes: the great Indian bustard in Rajasthan’s grasslands, the Sangai in Manipur’s wetlands, the dugong in coastal seagrass meadows and the hangul in Kashmir’s forests. The list is a starting point; India’s National Red List Assessment can show where focused efforts are needed next.

India launched its National Red List Roadmap at the IUCN World Conservation Congress in Abu Dhabi in 2025; the aim was to produce National Red Data Books for plants and animals by 2030. India occupies just 2.4% of the world’s land area, yet supports nearly 8% of its flora and 7.5% of its fauna. It is one of 17 megadiverse countries and contains parts of four of the world’s 36 biodiversity hotspots. Around 28% of its plants and more than 30% of its animals are found nowhere else. Of the 7,516 Indian animal species assessed for the IUCN Red List, 1,012 are threatened, which includes Vulnerable, Endangered and Critically Endangered species.

These assessments cover only 7.2% of India’s documented animal species. The figure of 1,012 tells us what is known so far, not the full extent of the threat. The National Red List Assessment can help close that gap and direct recovery efforts where they are needed most.

The projects in States

In Tamil Nadu, Project Nilgiri Tahr combines population surveys, radio-collaring, habitat assessment and mapping across Tamil Nadu and Kerala to conserve the tahr, which is the State animal of Tamil Nadu. Working with the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), the Advanced Institute for Wildlife Conservation, the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), the Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Sciences University



Supriya Sahu

A senior administrator in the Government of Tamil Nadu, who has worked extensively on environmental policy, ecosystem restoration, wildlife and biodiversity conservation and climate action. She is a recipient of the UNEP Champions of the Earth award 2025



Yash Veer Bhatnagar

The Country Representative for the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) in India, and a scientist with over three decades of experience in conservation science and practice. He received the SANCTUARY Asia Wildlife Service Award in 2015

The current state of some of India’s endangered species is encouraging, but sustained conservation, science and local action remain essential

India’s stakes in the Global Pandemic Agreement



Privadarshini Singh

Research Fellow at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP)

Shaping the framework

The PA was adopted by 124 member-states in 2025, including India. No country voted against it, while 11 abstained, reflecting alignment across high-, middle- and low-income countries (HICs/LICs/LMICs). The negotiations hinged on how to balance national sovereignty with international cooperation and solidarity, exposing the fault lines between the Global North and the Global South. Key issues included whether a global treaty can set binding targets for measures such as ‘One Health’ without securing funding for countries with fragile health systems. Or whether national pandemic regulations can be harmonised through global frameworks. And whether private manufacturers can be required to share vaccines in real time at affordable prices.

The PA is not yet open for ratification because negotiations are still ongoing for an annex concerning the Pathogen Access and Benefit-Sharing (PABS) system. PABS could help ensure that, during a pandemic, LICs and LMICs receive a fair share of vaccines, medicines and other therapeutics.

Even without ratification, the PA has created a first-of-its-kind global legal regime for the PPPR. Operationalisation requires countries such as India to balance interests of the HICs, LICs and LMICs. This will determine whether the PA will further entrench the inequities of the COVID-19 pandemic or make global health governance truly inclusive.

At the UN HLM, India succeeded in enshrining the multilateral components of the PA within the principle of national sovereignty. India reiterated its commitment to strengthen global pandemic preparedness but stressed that effective

(TANUVAS) and other partners, the project is strengthening the scientific understanding needed to secure the tahr’s future. Surveys recorded 1,303 tahrs in 2025 and 1,364 in 2026.

Vulture conservation is an example of how sustained action through conservation breeding, safer habitats, monitoring and public awareness can help reverse a devastating decline. India’s ban on the veterinary use of diclofenac, which had caused catastrophic losses in vulture populations, was a crucial step in this effort. At Pinjore, the Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre, run by the Haryana Forest Department and the Bombay Natural History Society, works with white-rumped, long-billed and slender-billed vultures. Madhya Pradesh’s 2025 census recorded 12,981 vultures, up from 8,397 in 2019. Tamil Nadu’s Segur Plateau remains an important habitat. Tamil Nadu’s raptor conservation work and synchronised surveys across Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Karnataka track these birds, which include breeding populations in the Mudumalai Tiger Reserve.

Long-term protection including habitat management, scientific monitoring and the help of local communities has helped the Asiatic lion in Gujarat – the population rose from 674 in 2020 to 891 in 2025, with lions occupying a wider part of Saurashtra.

Monitoring, grassland management, invasive plant control, research and translocation have helped secure and expand greater one-horned rhinoceros populations against poaching. In Assam’s Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary, which has an exceptionally high rhino density, working with communities on awareness, monitoring, livelihoods and conflict reduction has made rhino protection an enduring part of the landscape.

In Meghalaya, the action plan for the clouded leopard, the elusive State animal, combines habitat protection and restoration, scientific monitoring, frontline training and community participation. As the animal is dispersed across the northeast, 14 priority landscapes have been identified as understanding population connections and keeping them intact are central to its future.

Dugong conservation calls for a different approach. Tamil Nadu established India’s first dugong conservation reserve across 448.34 square kilometres of the Palk Bay and its seagrass habitat. A 2026 Wildlife Institute of India assessment estimated a total of 270 dugongs, including 158 dugongs in the Palk Bay and 112 in the Gulf of Mannar, providing a baseline for measuring change. Fishermen who release dugongs caught in nets may lose valuable gear. But the government provides compensation for damaged nets and recognises their efforts.

High up in the Himalayas, science and local stewardship have helped the snow leopard. In

pandemic management requires that international coordination is demonstrated. The first is equitable access to drugs, vaccines and therapeutics and the creation of global public goods, such as digital infrastructure (which admittedly align with its own national priorities).

The second is a respect for national sovereignty and the primacy of member-states in shaping global policy interventions according to national circumstance. As a contrast, the United States rejected the Declaration, calling the PABS and WHO’s role in declaring pandemics as a challenge to its national interests.

India’s line

In its remarks, India has acknowledged the concerns of the Global North and the South. Both sides have upheld national sovereignty as paramount on several provisions. The African countries did not give consent to commitments to monitor the human-animal-environment interface, a key source of pandemic outbreaks, without significant funding, which was not guaranteed by the Global North. Similarly, countries in the Global North did not want binding targets with regards to technology transfer (and other similar provisions).

But as India said at the UN HLM, ‘Global Solidarity must be demonstrated through action’; India must be an active player in the finalisation of the global PPPR regime. India is already actively engaged in the PABS negotiations and must lead the Global South in the post PABS context. India can consider three options. First, developing partnerships on technical areas of the PA (One Health, surveillance, health workforce strengthening) to build trust with other countries in the Global South, and a ‘store’ of operational solutions to tricky national sovereignty problems.

Second, leveraging its leadership role within existing global political groupings. For example, the H20 summit (a health and development G-7 and G-20 partnership) will take place under the United Kingdom’s G-20 leadership at the end of 2027; pandemic preparedness is one of the core health agendas. During India’s G-20 presidency in

2024, India’s first scientific population assessment estimated 718 snow leopards. In Himachal Pradesh, women from Kibber have worked with Forest Department field teams, the Snow Leopard Trust and the Nature Conservation Foundation to set camera traps, monitor population and participate in protection activities.

Political support is essential

Much depends on the commitment of State governments. Political leadership is crucial in prioritising the recovery of species, bringing government departments together and, most importantly sustaining action through successive budgets. Transferring that commitment into land use, infrastructure and livelihood decisions are what will help recovery plans being implemented. State forest teams have to turn plans into work on the ground. Recovery requires lasting cooperation with communities, scientists and national agencies. Results may take years, and setbacks require programmes to adapt. This would require clear goals, steady investment and careful monitoring.

Species that receive little public attention can struggle to attract funding. State-level funds can bring government, industry, philanthropy and scientific institutions together around local priorities. Tamil Nadu’s recently established Endangered Species Conservation Fund reflects this approach, with its focus on the mahseer, striped hyena, Madras hedgehog, lion-tailed macaque and the hornbill.

There is similar commitment internationally. Launched in 2026 by Re:wild and the Bezos Earth Fund, the Phoenix Species Project has committed \$200 million to recovering 100 of the world’s most threatened species, by supporting conservationists, indigenous peoples and local communities over several years. This is a lesson for India: recovery needs dependable resources for habitats, monitoring and the people doing the work.

Forest departments need scientific support close to the field and staff need to be trained in surveys, habitat assessment, conservation breeding and genetic analysis. Communities must be involved meaningfully in surveys, habitat work and ground decisions. Their knowledge can sharpen plans and their true participation can sustain them.

For India, a national picture of risk can guide priorities; States, scientists and communities can translate them into plans with mapped habitats, clear timelines and measurable outcomes. The bustard, vulture, tahr and dugong show that species recover in different ways. But their survival depends on sustained effort – to learn, to act and to stay with a species long enough for its future to change.

2023, India launched the Global Initiative for Digital Health and holds considerable influence within the platform’s health initiatives. Another is ‘Partners for Multilateralism’, which was launched in 2026 by the European Union (co-sponsors are Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada, India and Kenya).

Third, strengthening and aligning domestic policy and regulatory architecture around its own priorities for the PA. Global leadership always rests on domestic strengths. India must ensure that its national policies on PPPR such as regulation of access to biological material and distribution of the benefits uphold the highest standards of equity which India can then demand at the global level.

A South-South health role

An equitable global regime on PPPR is in India’s interests as much as a responsibility towards the Global South. India is the pharmacy of the world, manufacturing one of the largest shares of vaccines in the world in terms of volume. Yet, it needs an equitable global vaccine distribution regime. The patents for the vaccines that India manufactures are held by global pharmaceuticals. India is also import-dependent for Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs).

India needs access to the latest technology from the Global North to strengthen the manufacturing of high-grade personal protective equipment and medical devices. At the same time, India needs to lead South-South Cooperation and share its technological strength with other countries in the Global South.

India’s health system has a continental scale, and as India’s Health Secretary stated at the UN HLM, its interventions in digital health infrastructure, laboratories networks and One Health are valuable as global public goods. An effective PA needs an engaged India, and a strong PA will strengthen India’s own pandemic management.

This article is based on a forthcoming CSEP working paper on the Pandemic Agreement

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Gendered welfare

On September 28, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam launched its flagship ‘Thai Maaman Thanga Modhiram [A gold ring from the maternal uncle]’ initiative, allocating an initial ₹560 crore to provide a one-gram gold ring and other essentials to eligible

newborns in the State. While presented as welfare, the scheme risks reinforcing the very gendered expectations that make daughters economically burdensome. Across India, rituals and kinship norms expect the father or the eldest son to bear expenses and provide gifts for the

daughters’ weddings. The brother must also bear gifts (seer) for her newborn and, if the children are female, bear gifts for their weddings too. Historically, such pressures have contributed to son preference and female foeticide in India. Society already harbours the regressive idea of

marriage as an economic transaction between two families. In this context, a government scheme that effectively provides dowry-like benefits to new mothers risks legitimising these expectations rather than challenging them. **Samyukta Mahesh,** Chennai

Examination portals

With immense frustration, I am compelled to express my views on the dismal state of Indian government examination websites. This is the seldom-discussed issue. The obsolete and user-‘un-friendly’ nature of sites is a burden. These sites suffer frequent glitches,

difficult navigation and no responsibility from the institution to respond in a timely way. They are difficult to access by differently-abled students.

Paritosh Chauhan, Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

AI companions and child safety

Traditionally, a child in distress has usually turned to a parent, friend or a counsellor. However, in today's world, that confidant is increasingly becoming an AI chatbot. Such AI companions are quietly finding a place in children's emotional lives because, unlike parents and friends, these apps are available at all times of the day, appear empathetic, and are endlessly responsive. But who assumes responsibility when that relationship turns harmful? As AI becomes an emotional confidant for children, India's regulatory framework must confront the growing risks of AI companionship.

In April 2025 in the U.S., 16-year-old Adam Raine died by suicide. His family alleged that ChatGPT had engaged in conversations about suicide with Mr. Raine for months and had even helped him draft a farewell note; they subsequently filed a wrongful-death lawsuit against OpenAI, the parent company of ChatGPT. While the litigation remains ongoing, the case has ignited a debate about the responsibilities of technology companies towards vulnerable children.

On September 10, 2026, California enacted the Senate Bill 1119, known as 'Adam's Law'. It introduces safeguards for AI companion chatbots, including crisis-detection protocols, parental controls, notifications when children disable safety settings, and independent safety audits. The legislation is a clear signal that technological innovation cannot be at the expense of child safety.

For India, this should serve as a regulatory wake-up call. Its digital



Sakshi Rewaria
Faculty, IIM Rohtak

landscape is witnessing an unprecedented expansion of young users who are interacting with AI-powered applications. Yet the nation's digital laws remain largely targeted towards conventional forms of cybercrime. While the Information Technology Act, 2000, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012, address important dimensions of digital safety, none establishes a comprehensive framework governing the psychological risks of AI companions. A chatbot's prolonged interactions with a child may raise serious concerns about emotional dependence, psychological manipulation, and exposure to harmful advice.

Unlike conventional cybercrime, AI-related psychological harm can be insidious and difficult to detect. Its effects may emerge through thousands of seemingly innocuous exchanges, shaped by product design and algorithmic responses. India's existing laws are not equipped to investigate this emerging category of harm.

The challenge, therefore, extends beyond the government; it also concerns the accountability of platforms whose products are becoming deeply embedded in children's emotional world.

Child safety is paramount

Article 21 guarantees the right to life and personal liberty, while Article 39(f) directs the state to ensure that children are given opportunities to develop in conditions of freedom and dignity. These constitutional principles acquire renewed

significance in the age of AI. Protecting children must now encompass their interactions in the digital space, not only with respect to their personal data and physical safety, but also from the risks arising from engagement with AI chatbots.

However, regulation must be calibrated. An excessively restrictive approach could stifle innovation, burden emerging enterprises, and impede the development of genuine AI progress. The objective should not be to hinder technological progress but to ensure that it takes accountability in stride. Age-appropriate safeguards, crisis-response mechanisms, independent safety assessments, and effective parental oversight are some of the reforms that can be considered. Such measures must also respect children's privacy and evolving autonomy.

California's legislative response offers India an opportunity to examine its own regulatory priorities. The objective need not be to replicate the U.S. legislation, but to develop a framework suited to India's institutional capacities and digital realities. Policymakers must also consider whether existing cybercrime investigation mechanisms are equipped to examine algorithmic behaviour, use chatbot interactions as evidence, and establish accountability whenever prolonged digital engagement result in harm.

The central question is not whether children will interact with AI; they already do. It is whether the institutions entrusted with their protection can keep pace with technologies that are transforming children's lives and childhood itself.

Property taxation needs structural reform

A robust property tax system is vital for India's cities. Property tax is not just the most important own revenue source for India's municipal bodies, it is also critical to bridge the gap in urban investment as such investment depends on municipal creditworthiness. However, the property tax performance of India's municipal bodies has been poor – India's cumulative property tax was 0.15-0.2% of its GDP, whereas it was 0.6% in middle-income countries and 0.3% in low-income countries. Policy efforts have sought to improve the property tax performance of India's municipal bodies through technology and process-based reforms recommended by successive Finance Commissions and national schemes such as the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission and the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation. Yet, tax outcomes remain sub-optimal. Why?

Two recent studies offer insights – a working paper on Chennai's property tax by Nobel Laureate Esther Duflo and co-authors, and this writer's research on Bengaluru, Pune and Ghaziabad's property tax. Both studies found that technology and process-based reforms will keep yielding sub-optimal results unless backed by structural reforms. Firstly, Duflo and co-authors' research in Chennai found that municipal human resources are a critical determinant of property tax outcomes. It also finds that a municipality's own tax assessors achieve far better tax outcomes compared to



Debarpita Roy
Lead-Research at the Centre for Public Policy on Housing and Habitat, NIUA, New Delhi. The views are personal

assessors from outsourced firms. The research conducted across Bengaluru, Pune and Ghaziabad finds that in addition to the issue of municipal human resource deficits, two other structural issues – irregularity in the conduct of elections and poor financial reporting practices – also impact tax outcomes.

Stages of property tax
There are three life stages of property tax – enumeration (identification of properties and maintenance of property records along with property details), property valuation and tax assessment, and tax billing and collection.

Technology has been a popular policy solution for improving enumeration. GIS-based mapping using satellite imagery and drones have been increasingly deployed to identify properties. However, such mapping exercises need to be accompanied by physical inspections conducted by municipal tax assessors; they also need to be repeated at regular intervals. But a perennial shortage of municipal staff, lack of requisite skills, and inadequate capacity building plague India's municipalities. While human resource outsourcing can be a substitute, its efficiency is limited as municipal assessors leverage institutional memory in a way that outsourced assessors cannot.

For valuation, the most common policy recommendation has been the capital valuation process, wherein a property is valued as per its stamp duty-linked 'circle rate' which is set and revised by the State revenue department at regular

intervals. But most municipal bodies follow a valuation method wherein the 'base rate' is defined in rupees per sq ft per month which is set by the municipality. Hence, tax buoyancy is determined by revisions to this base rate. But such revisions are infrequent compared to revisions in the stamp duty-linked circle rate. It was found that 'base rate' revisions did not take place across Bengaluru, Pune and Ghaziabad when there were no elected municipal councils. The link between municipal elections and tax performance is clear, at least for these three corporations. As delayed municipal elections are common, so is infrequent 'base rate' revision and lack of tax buoyancy.

Finally, for tax collections to be robust, collection efficiency needs to be strong. While extant recommendations include adoption of both online collection as well as outsourcing the collection to external vendors, efficiency remains poor. Even more concerning is the difficulty in arriving at credible collection efficiency estimates due to the absence of properly maintained financial accounts.

To sum up, technology and process-based reforms are not enough for improving tax outcomes. Structural reforms encompassing more human resources, timely elections, and publicly available financial data play very important roles. It is high time that policy interventions broaden their focus to structural reforms for all aspects of urban governance and finance, including property tax.

India struggles to curb leprosy transmission

India continues to report more leprosy cases, childhood infections and disability than projected, highlighting the need to interrupt transmissions

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani
Nitika Francis

India's leprosy programme is falling short of several projections set for 2025-26. The country reported 91,783 new leprosy cases in 2025-26, 41.2% higher than the projected 65,000. New cases among children were 91.6% above the projection while the rate of Grade 2 Disability (G2D) among new cases was 1.34 per million, against a projected one per million (**Table 1**).

India's national prevalence rate was 0.56 cases per 10,000 population at the end of March 2026, below the elimination target of a prevalence rate below one case per 10,000 (**Chart 1**). But the burden remains concentrated geographically. Chhattisgarh had the highest prevalence among States/UTs at 1.66 cases per 10,000 population, followed by Jharkhand (1.51), Chandigarh (1.49), Odisha (1.25) and Maharashtra (1.14) (**Map 1**).

At the district level, 14.8% of districts had a prevalence rate above one case per 10,000 in 2025-26, down from 18.6% in 2013-14 (**Chart 2**) but 114 districts still remained above the programme's elimination target. Moreover, only 148 districts have provisionally achieved interruption of transmission, against a projected 300.

G2D was also concentrated in a few States/UTs. Chandigarh, Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Odisha together accounted for 42.5% of the 1,945 G2D cases reported in 2025-26. Chandigarh recorded the highest rate at 13.54 per million, followed by Delhi (11.53) and Chhattisgarh (7.87) (**Chart 3**).

Single-Dose Rifampicin Post-Exposure Prophylaxis (SDR PEP), a preventive dose given to people who have been in contact with a leprosy patient, was administered to 91.2% of the 16.94 lakh eligible contacts in 2025-26, up from 71.4% of the 6.48 lakh in 2019-20 (**Chart 4**).

Leprosy burden

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Leprosy Eradication Programme annual report (2025-26). The projections mentioned in Table 1 are from the National Strategic Plan and Roadmap for Leprosy 2023-2027 published in 2023



Changing lives: Gnanodaya school located at Venkatapuram in Kanchipuram district admits children of leprosy patients. SHAJU JOHN

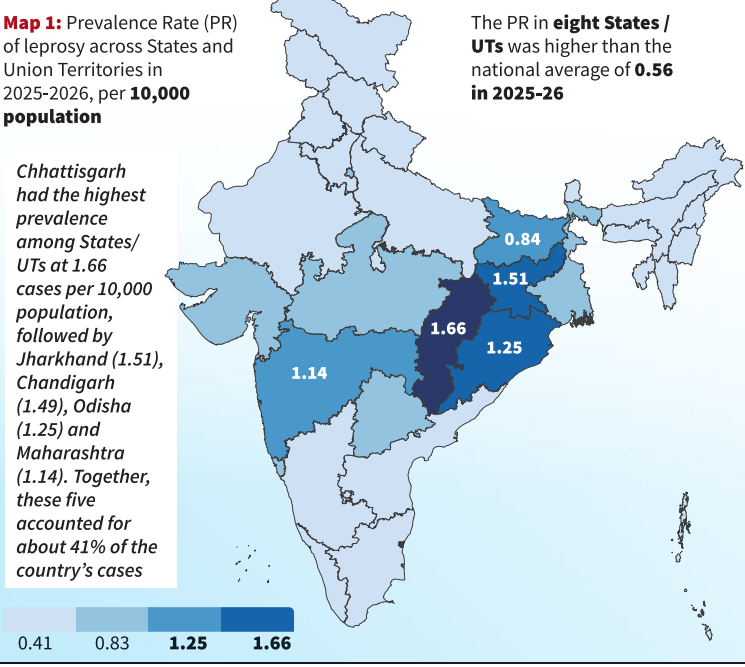
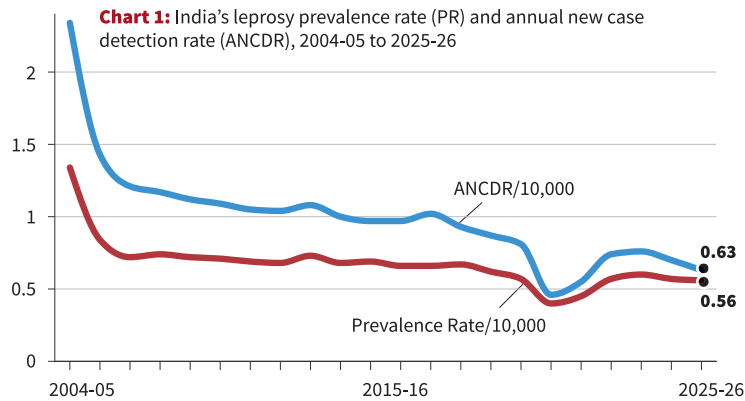
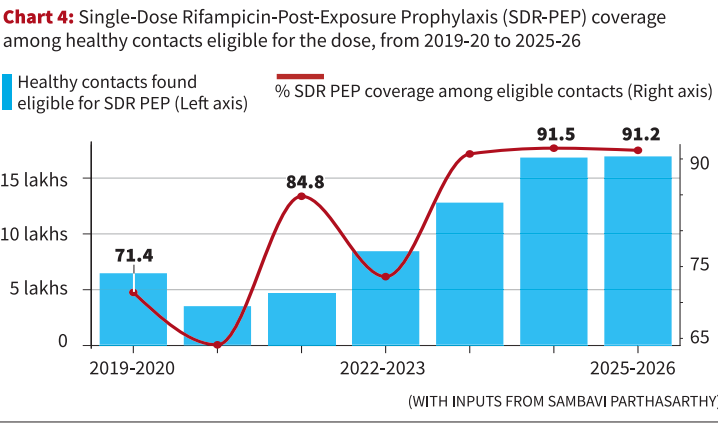
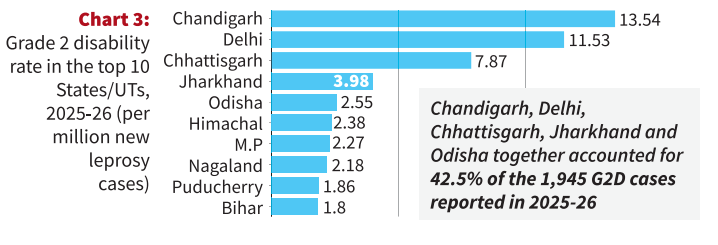
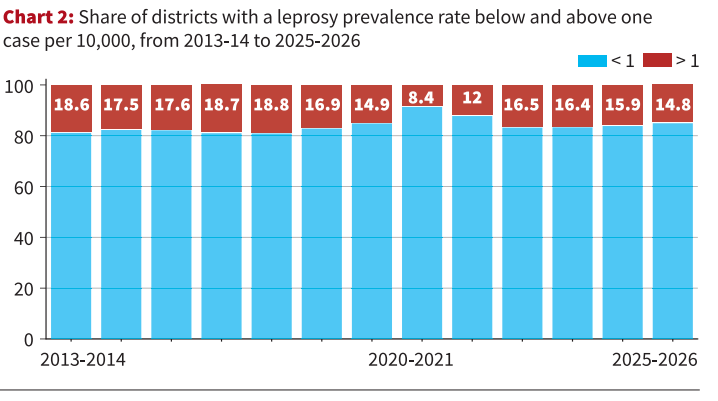


Table 1: Projections vs actual figures for key indicators. *provisionally achieved interruption of transmission

Indicator	2025-26 projection	2025-26 actual	Gap
Annual new leprosy cases	65,000	91,783	26,783 above (+41.2%)
Child cases (annual new)	2,000	3,832	1,832 above (+91.6%)
Child cases with G2D	25	37	12 above (+48%)
G2D rate in new cases (per million)	1	1.34	0.34 above (+34%)
Districts achieving interruption of transmission	300	148*	152 short (49.3%)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu**

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 8, 1976

Scope for India-UAE co-operation

New Delhi, October 7: The President, Mr. Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, said on his return here to-day from a four-day State visit to the United Arab Emirates (UAE) that there was plenty of goodwill for the Indian leadership and the people there.

The UAE leaders fully appreciated the achievements in the "internal conditions of our country and the effort we are making to bring about normalisation of relations with our neighbours and for lasting peace", Mr. Ahmed told newsmen at Delhi airport.

The Vice-President, Mr. B.D. Jatti, the Prime Minister, Mrs. Indira Gandhi, Central Ministers, the Congress President, Mr. D.K. Barooah and MPs were among those present at the airport to receive Mr. Ahmed.

Regarding his talks with the UAE leaders, Mr. Ahmed said he found plenty of similarity in "our approach to international problems."

He said, "they believe in the policy of non-alignment, peaceful co-existence and feel that it is the only way to bring about a just world."

Mr. Ahmed told Indian correspondents who accompanied him on his visit to the UAE that in his talks with the UAE leaders he had found a sincere desire on their part to give a new turn to the relationship between India and the UAE in conformity with the requirements of the present technological world.

Both Sheikh Zayed, President of the UAE and Sheikh Rashed, Vice-President, told him that developing countries like India and the UAE, should have closer economic co-operation because "our requirements are similar".

The UAE leaders were of the view that it would be profitable for the developing countries to promote as much economic cooperation as possible among themselves.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 8, 1926

London's 'street of silence'

London, October 7: The City Corporation is carrying out an interesting experiment in Black-friar's neighbourhood repairing the street by means of terra cotta blocks on which there is a covering of rubber. It is claimed that this first "rubber street" in the world is soundless, dustless, nonskidding and more durable.

THE HINDU

60 in per cent. Meghalaya has recorded a 60% rain deficit due to the impact of the El Niño weather phenomenon, with Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma saying his government has initiated mitigation measures by formulating a water policy and satellite mapping around 17,000 springs. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

BIBLIOGRAPHY



Jeffrey Archer. REUTERS

Jeffrey Archer and the art of turning trouble into stories

His novels were dismissed by critics but devoured by readers; from political success and literary fame to scandal, imprisonment, and renewed success, Archer repeatedly turned both triumph and disgrace into material for his books

Uma Mahadevan-Dasgupta

My father, who died at the age of 90 last month, enjoyed reading the British author and former politician Jeffrey Archer’s novels. Ever since he bought the first one, *Not a Penny More, Not a Penny Less* (1976) at an airport bookstore in the late 1970s, he became a fan. In the later years of his life, when he found it difficult to focus on serious texts, I often saw my father rereading Archer’s novels – though he did not care for the prison memoirs.

His own life

Archer’s books, however flat and formulaic the prose, are compulsively readable. Beginning with the opening lines of his first novel: “Making a million legally has always been difficult. Making a million illegally has always been a little easier. Keeping a million when you have made it is perhaps the most difficult of all.” Four men – an Oxford academic, a doctor, an art dealer, and a peer – have been swindled out of their life’s savings by the shady multi-millionaire Harvey Metcalfe. The four strangers come together to plan a heist and get their money back, to the last penny, in an entertaining *Ocean’s Eleven* kind of caper novel.

According to Archer, who died aged 86 this week, the novel was based on his own experience and his urgent need for income. He had been one of the youngest Members of Parliament of his time,

elected in 1969 as a Conservative MP, but a failed investment and near-bankruptcy in 1974 compelled him to stand down from his parliamentary seat and sell the family house.

The novel reportedly sold only 3,000 copies initially, but went on to become a bestseller. Meanwhile, his wife Mary’s academic job at Cambridge kept the family afloat while Archer began his writing career.

Scale of ambition

While critics dismiss Archer’s fiction for the potboiler style, contrivance, and melodrama, readers across the world keep buying his books, especially in airports and railway bookstalls, and even pirated copies at traffic signals. It is not only the plot or the fast pace that grabs their attention, but also the sheer scale of ambition. *Kane and Abel* (1979), Archer’s bestselling novel, which has reportedly sold 50 million copies across the world, is a saga of capitalism and enterprise. The two main characters are born in very different circumstances and have very different lives, but along with a common birthday, they share a limitless ambition. Both are given tumultuous childhoods spanning continents: a forest birth, a war, Siberia, a death on the *Titanic*. The banker William Kane is a member of the Boston elite; the businessman Abel Rosnovski is a Polish immigrant in America. Through the Great Depression, the Second World War, and beyond, the two men’s lives are connected in ways

they do not fully realise until it is too late. Of course, being an Archer novel, the most enduring connection is made when their children meet. This golden goose of a story continues over three generations and two more novels.

If Archer’s middlebrow fiction keeps returning to themes of meteoric rise, ruin, and recovery, it is perhaps because his life did the same, except with far more self-promotion and hubris. He was born in London in 1940 and grew up in Weston-super-Mare, a childhood hometown that would later return in his career as his title and entry into the House of Lords.

Archer’s first novel was born out of his troubles, and so were his prison diaries, years later. Between these books came years in public life, a hunger for visibility, a tendency to self-promotion, and an inveterate snobbishness: a Conservative Party deputy chairmanship, a peerage, and a London mayoral candidacy that ended in 1999. A key point in the midst of this trajectory was a 1987 libel case against the tabloid newspaper *Daily Star* for its allegation that he had slept with a prostitute, Monica Coghlan. Although Archer won £500,000 in damages, his testimony was later shown to be false, leading to his conviction in 2001 for perjury and perverting the course of justice.

Writing in jail

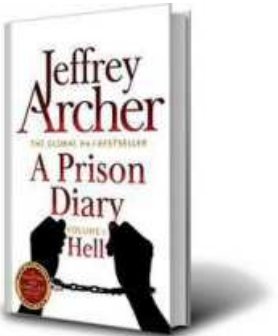
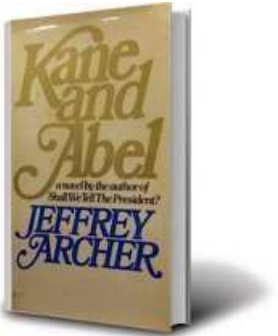
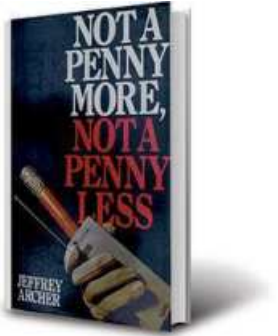
“As we draw up to the entrance gate, I see a sign declaring BELMARSH PRISON.

Some wag has put a line through the B and replaced it with an H. Not the most propitious of welcomes.”

A Prison Diary is a three-volume account of Archer’s life in multiple prisons: Belmarsh, Wayland, North Sea Camp, and Lincoln.

In the first volume, written after three weeks in jail, Archer doesn’t reflect on the reasons why he has been sentenced to serve time in the high-security prison. Egregiously, and self-servingly, he prefaces the narrative with William Henley’s poem *Invictus* – the poem that Nelson Mandela famously drew sustenance from during his 27 years of imprisonment. Elsewhere, Archer alludes to Oscar Wilde. Nevertheless, *A Prison Diary* is no *De Profundis*, and Archer is no victim other than of his own vanities. With a stubborn refusal to reflect on his own acts or hubris, he comments disdainfully about other prisoners and the reasons for their incarceration. About the first volume (2002), *Kirkus Reviews* noted: “Archer is a known recidivist. He will write again.” Prescient words, for Archer would write two more volumes of his prison diary.

Making a million is hard, and keeping it harder. It involves ambition and occasionally its uglier synonym, greed. Archer made his millions, lost them, rebuilt his life, and, in the end, refused to reflect on his doings. Instead, he packaged and sold the prison years as well, fully monetising his disgrace. (Uma Mahadevan Dasgupta is in the IAS)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “kicking it back”? (L. Balagopal, Hyderabad) When you “kick back”, “kick it back”, or “kick it”, what you are doing is relaxing. If you are sitting at home with your friends doing absolutely nothing, you can say that you are “just kicking it”. This expression is considered to be slang and therefore used only in informal contexts. Here are a few examples.

After the exam, my friends and I kicked it at home last night.

Some people complain that most government employees go to the office, just kick it back until they have to go home.

This expression has more or less the same meaning as “chill out”.

I have told Vyomakesh to chill out after the exams.

What is the positive reply to, “Won’t you eat”? (V. Krishnan, Palghat) If you want to eat, then you would have to say, “Yes, I will”. If you want to sound very polite, you could say, “Yes, I will. Thank you.” If the person is well known to you, then you could simply say, “Of course”, “Sure”, “Why not?”, “Love to”, etc.

What is the meaning of “hydrophobia”? (M. Amarnath, Kodaikanal) “Hydro” means water; so it stands to reason that “hydrophobia” is fear of water. If a person is hydrophobic, does he/she ever take a bath? Worth looking into, don’t you think? Someone should write a dissertation on this. Maybe we should all become hydrophobic during the summer. One way of saving water!

What is the meaning of the idiom “to fish in troubled waters”? (Nividha, Visakhapatnam) When you fish in troubled waters, what you are doing is involving yourself in a dangerous situation in the hope of gaining some personal advantage. In other words, you hope to capitalise on someone else’s misfortune. Something that our political parties and politicians are famous for. When a country fishes in troubled waters, what it is attempting to do is to gain advantage from the political problems that the other country is having.

Here are a few examples. *Bela is fishing in troubled waters by buying shares of that software company. I understand that the company is in financial difficulties.*

Many American arms companies have been fishing in troubled waters for several decades now by selling armaments to states that are potential sponsors of terrorism. The Prime Minister denied that his Government was fishing in troubled waters.

Fishermen believe that it is easy to catch fish when the water is “troubled” or rough. Some believe that the fish come to the surface at this time and therefore it is easier to catch them. Others argue that fish don’t “bite” any better in bad weather than in good weather. They feel that the bad weather drives away most fishermen and, as a result, the few that remain catch more fish. *Published in The Hindu on March 12, 2002*

THE DAILY QUIZ

On this day in 1967, Che Guevara was captured in a Bolivian ravine: a quiz on asthmatic medical student who became the most recognisable face of 20th-century revolution

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1 Ernesto Guevara was born on 14 June 1928 in which Argentine city on the Paraná river?

QUESTION 2 Where does the nickname “Che” come from?

QUESTION 3 As a hard-tackling schoolboy rugby player, he was nicknamed “Füser.” What was it short for?

QUESTION 4 What was the nickname of the 1939 Norton 500

motorcycle on which he and Alberto Granado made their 1952 journey across South America?

QUESTION 5 In 1954, in which country did he watch a CIA-backed coup topple President Jacobo Árbenz, an experience that hardened his views of the U.S.?

QUESTION 6 In 2007, it emerged that Mario Terán, the soldier who shot Che, had received what from Cuban doctors?



Visual Question: Identify the photographer who captured this famous image of Che Guevara at the memorial service for the victims of the La Coubre explosion. MUSEO DE COMANDANCIA DEL CHE, HAVANA

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. The 85 medals tally is India’s second-highest ever haul at an Asian Games, following the record 107 at Hangzhou 2022. With which country did India tie for the gold medals with 21? **Ans: Uzbekistan, but claimed fourth place outright due to a superior silver medal count** 2. Who was the only Indian to win all three types of medals, and in which events? **Ans: Vithya Ramraj, who brought home gold in the women’s 4x400m relay, silver in the mixed 4x400m relay, and bronze in the 400m hurdles** 3. At 15 years, 6 months, and 6 days old, who became India’s youngest-ever gold medal winner? **Ans: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (cricket)** 4. Which sport gave India the maximum gold medals with five? **Ans: Archery** 5. Apart from Neeru Dhandu in shooting, who also returned with two gold medals to his/her name? **Ans: Kumkum Mohod (archery)** 6. Pincky Balhara and Suchika Tariyal won bronze medals in which contact sports? **Ans: Kurash and MMA** Visual: Identify her. She became the first Indian woman to win individual gold in which sport? **Ans: Pranavi Urs in golf** **Early Birds:** Piyali Tuli | Tito Shiladiyya | Pulkit Sathe | Sitaram Saharay | Sadhan Panda

Word of the day

Germane: relating to something in an important or appropriate way

Synonyms: relevant, applicable, pertinent, to the point

Usage: *She asked a germane question about the proposal.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/germane

International Phonetic Alphabet: /dʒɜːmeɪn/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

From Page One

Protests will go on until CEC resigns, says Rahul

There were dramatic scenes during the three-hour-long bus procession and the subsequent impromptu sit-in at the roundabout as the Opposition MPs were stopped by security personnel. Delhi Police personnel first forcibly removed Mr. Gandhi, carrying him on their shoulders, and put him inside a police van. “This is all panic reaction, this is all fear,” Mr. Gandhi said while sitting inside the van after his detention.

As Congress workers punctured one of the van’s tyres, it could travel only a short distance. Mr. Gandhi was taken to the Barakhamba Road police station and released by 8 p.m. A visual of Ms. Vadra lying on her back on the street, clutching a copy of the Constitution, went viral on social media. A large contingent of women police personnel then removed Ms. Vadra and other women leaders who were lying on the road in protest.

“This is how they treat Members of Parliament who are asking simply to meet the Election Commissioners. This is how they treat us. They are beating Members of Parliament. Their policemen have scratched me all over,” Ms. Vadra alleged.

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy and his Keralam counterpart V.D. Satheesan were also part of the protests.

The police had stopped the buses carrying Opposition MPs, including Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal, at the roundabout near the Le Meridien and Shangri-La hotels.

Leaders of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA), however, are likely to continue with the protests on Thursday as well, top Congress leaders indicated.

“To save the Constitution and democracy, the Congress Party and the Opposition are ready to take to the streets as many times as needed, face arrests, or endure legal cases,” the Congress president said in a post on X.

“Arresting LOP @RahulGandhiji has become a hobby for this fascist regime. We are watching the total destruction of Indian democracy in real time. These criminals in Delhi Police uniform will pay a heavy price for how they have manhandled Rahul ji and priyankagandhiji,” Mr. Venugopal said, adding that the Opposition would return “day after day until vote *chors* [thieves] are brought to justice”.

Earlier in the day, the Delhi Police had registered an FIR against Mr. Gandhi, Ms. Vadra and others for staging a dharna inside the premises of Akashvani Bhavan.

RBI raises repo rate to 5.5% amid ‘tightening’

“The duration and extent of the rate hike cycle would be contingent on the actual growth-inflation developments and outlook, especially that of underlying inflation, the extent of broadening of price pressures and second-round effects of the supply shock, as also the impact of demand impulses. Although global growth remains resilient, it is projected to decelerate in 2026 from the previous year. Driven by escalating energy costs and rising food prices, global inflation is projected to increase sharply prompting monetary policy tightening by major central banks,” he said.

“Lingering trade uncertainty, rising bond yields in advanced economies and an appreciating dollar are keeping global financial market sentiments nervous and fragile,” he said.

On the rationale for the MPC’s decision, the Governor said, “The MPC noted that the global context on account of geopolitical developments remains challenging. Nonetheless, the Indian economy has been strong, and the economic momentum remains broad-based. Moreover, the economy is expected to remain resilient.”

“It further observed that in light of available data, it is clear that inflation and its outlook are not benign as they were last year, with headline CPI (consumer price index) inflation expected to average almost 5.8% in the next three quarters and core inflation projected at 4.4% this financial year,” he said.

On supply-side inflation, the MPC noted that monetary policy primarily acts by curtailing second-round effects. “Apart from data related to inflation expectations and firm level pricing behaviour, indicators of generalisation of inflation like core inflation and diffusion indices are used for this purpose. It may, however, be kept in mind that it is difficult to distinguish between the second-round effects and the indirect impact of supply side pressures as both are present in these indicators,” he said.

Former First Lady of Sri Lanka arrested

Mr. Namal Rajapaksa was arrested over corruption allegations in a 2013 Airbus aircraft deal signed when his father, Mr. Mahinda Rajapaksa, was President, and an ongoing probe into bribery allegations linked to Indian property development company Krrish’s real estate project in Sri Lanka. Eliminating corruption was among the chief poll pledges of President Anura Kumara Disanayake, who completed two years in office recently. Addressing a rally of famers in Polonnaruwa district in Sri Lanka’s North Central Province last month, President Disanayake said that he had “no sympathy for anyone”, and “whether the mother or the grandmother” everyone must face the law.

PM moots ‘can-do attitude’ to reach development goals

140 crore citizens together will build a developed India by 2047, says Modi in speech marking 25 years in public office; cites ‘lifting 25 crore people out of poverty’ as a key achievement of his govt.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday marked 25 years in public office by urging Indians to adopt a “we will do it” attitude to achieve development goals by 2047.

Mr. Modi was addressing the “Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha” on completing 25 years in public office, first as Chief Minister of Gujarat (from October 2001 to May 2014) and then as Prime Minister of India, in an unbroken sequence. “There is no reason for India to stop. A hundred years ago, there were less than 40 crore of us. Today, we are more than 140 crore. The 140 crore citizens together will build a developed India by 2047, and we certainly will. We will do it,” he said.

The goals include seeing India among the top three economies of the world, achieving self-reliance as a global manufacturing hub, hosting the Olympics, and stepping into space.

“This energy, this enthusiasm, this confidence is extraordinary,” Mr. Modi said, adding that he bowed before people of the coun-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressing the Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium in New Delhi. PTI

try who had placed their trust in him. “For me, people are God. Hardworking BJP workers are my strength,” Mr. Modi said. He said his well-wishers encouraged him and his critics taught him to look within.

“Twenty-five years ago, at the age of 50, I spent my time serving tribal communities in the forests and living amidst the mountains, eventually choosing the path of organisational work within the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). My political report card reflected only the work of an organisational worker. I had been involved in elections, yet I had never contested one myself,” he said.

He said he had never personally pursued electoral prominence.

“Had I desired to shine in electoral politics, I could have entered the arena long ago, but that was not my temperament. I never even stopped to consider what I would become in life or what my future held,” Mr. Modi said.

His life’s path, he said, had been shaped by the singular principle that “the upbringing and values instilled in me since childhood taught me to live my life for a mission, not for personal ambition”.

Highlighting his government’s achievements in different sectors, the Prime Minister said that what

once seemed unimaginable had become possible, and lifting 25 crore people out of poverty was an example of it.

“That is why I believe in the strength and potential of 140 crore Indians. After 25 years of experience, I can say with confidence that we are witnessing India’s transformation right before our eyes,” he said.

Praises Smit Machchhar

Referring to Captain Smit Machchhar, the Indian fly-dubai pilot who foiled an attempt by his co-pilot to crash an Israel-bound flight despite being stabbed, Mr. Modi said the world was talking about India’s pilot today, and a day would come when the world would talk about ‘Made in India’ aircraft.

He noted that one of the biggest challenges the country faced was the division of society along the line of votes. “But when a farmer’s field lacks water, does the problem affect only one caste? When there is no electricity, does darkness fall only on one community? The answer is ‘no’. If the problem belongs to everyone, the solution must be for everyone,” Mr. Modi said.

Will happily follow party’s instructions: Harish Rawat

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Days after the Congress central leadership, including All India Congress Committee general secretary K.C. Venugopal, asked him to stop his Dhanyawad Evam Jansamvad Yatra, former Uttarakhand Chief Minister and Congress veteran Harish Rawat said he would comply with the party’s directions on his ongoing political programmes.

Mr. Venugopal, who said he had spoken to Mr. Rawat amid concerns over his individual political programmes in the State, took to X to announce that he had made it clear to Mr. Rawat that the Congress’s election campaign in Uttarakhand would be conducted jointly with all its leaders.

This came days after Uttarakhand in-charge Kumari Selja, in a letter to Mr. Rawat on Thursday, asked him not to continue with the yatra, stressing the need for the party to present a united front.

After concluding his yatra on Tuesday, Mr. Rawat told *The Hindu* that he would bow to pressure from the Congress leadership over his ongoing yatra.

“If I am in the party, why would I not accept the party’s pressure?” he said.

Mr. Rawat insisted that his yatra was never a parallel programme.

“No Congress programme was running when I took out the yatra,” he said, adding that he attended all programmes whenever he was asked to. He also claimed that several senior Congress leaders from Uttarakhand had attended his yatra.

He said the yatra was meant to thank those who had come to enquire after him during a serious illness that had kept him away from public life for about four months.

Press bodies demand FIR in alleged assault on women journalists

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Indian Women’s Press Corps, Press Club of India, Delhi Union of Journalists, Press Association, and Kerala Union of Journalists on Wednesday demanded registration of a case against a Delhi police officer for alleged sexual assault on three women journalists at Jantar Mantar. They also sought an “impartial judicial inquiry” into the charges.

“We wish to draw your attention to the fact that no FIR has yet been registered against Shri Vivek Bhagat, ACP, for his alleged sexual assault on three women journalists on October 3 at the protest site. This is a clear violation of the law that holds that the police are duty bound to register an FIR immediately on a complaint,” said the press bodies’ memorandum to

Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar.

‘This is unacceptable’

The memorandum said: “It is the duty of the police stationed there to ensure that the press is allowed to do their job. Instead there is heavy handedness and even brutality in dealing with journalists. This is unacceptable.”

“The Delhi police needs to recognise the growing presence of independent journalists running their own channels and pages and having substantial followers. Today, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook and X form a major source of news and views. Not all of these journalists, many of them women, have formal accreditation. Yet they should not be denied their right to report through writing, video, or photography due to unreasonable restrictions,” it added.

2 children among 3 killed in Delhi building collapse

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Two children and a pregnant woman were killed and eight persons injured after a four-storey building collapsed in New Seemapuri of northeast Delhi on Wednesday.

Eleven people have been pulled out from the debris so far even as operations are on to rescue people trapped in the rubble, the police said.

The deceased woman was four months’ pregnant. The two children, one of whom was 12 years old, are yet to be identified.

Northeast Delhi District Magistrate Ajay Kumar said the structure collapsed between 3 p.m. and 3.15 p.m. “We immediately intimated all relevant authorities, including the NDRF [National Disaster Response Force], DDMA [District Disaster Management Authority] and MCD [Mun-

Leaders from various countries across the world on Wednesday extended greetings to Prime Minister Narendra Modi for completing 25 years as the elected head of a government, first as Chief Minister of Gujarat from October 2001 and then as the Prime Minister from May 2014.

Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi, through an X post, noted that Mr. Modi had dedicated himself to the development of Indian society and the nation over the years. “I express my deep respect for your achievements in advancing India’s development and elevating its standing in the international community,” she said.

“To realise a ‘Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP)’, Japan and India, which share strategic directions, will further strengthen our partnership through even closer collaboration with Modi.”

Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever also congratulated Mr. Modi. “Following my productive visit to India last month, I look forward to further deepening the strong partnership between our two countries,” he said.

Bhutanese Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay called

‘Golden’ chapter in the history of India, says Shah

GURUGRAM

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday described Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s 25 years in public office, first as Chief Minister of Gujarat and then Prime Minister, as a “golden” chapter in the history of Indian democracy. Addressing the ‘Viksit Bharat Sankalp Sabha – Seva Jyoti Yatra’, he said Mr. Modi had completed 25 years in public office by taking “crores and crores of people” along with him.

Mr. Modi “an avatar of our times”. Botswana’s President Duma Gideon Boko said: “We commend you for your dedication and service to the people of India. We wish you success in the years ahead and look forward to the enduring friendship between our countries,” she added.

“From Gujarat to leading the world’s largest democracy, Modi’s journey has been marked by a strong emphasis on good governance, innovation, technology, infrastructure and development, contributing to India’s transformation and its growing role on the global stage,” said Philippines President Bongbong Marcos.



Rescue operation under way after a four-storey building collapsed in the New Seemapuri area of Delhi on Wednesday. PTI

icipal Corporation of Delhi,” he said. Mr. Kumar said the rescued people included tenants in the building and some passers-by. “We found that the adjacent building had some demolition work going on, which could have affected the strength of this building,” he said.

Rescue squads located and contacted those trapped under the debris, with the NDRF deploying sniffer dogs. “We have established contact with peo-

ple trapped under the debris. We can hear them, and they will be rescued soon. It was a residential building... The collapse has also affected two adjoining buildings,” said Rajendra Prasad Meena, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Shahdara).

The building had developed a crack after tremors were felt in the national capital on Tuesday night following a 4.9-magnitude earthquake in Uttarakhand’s Chamoli.

Govt. opposes mercy petition of convict in CM assassination case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has opposed a plea by death-row convict Balwant Singh Rajoana seeking commutation of the death sentence awarded to him in the 1995 assassination of former Punjab Chief Minister Beant Singh. Rajoana, who has been in custody for more than 30 years, approached the Supreme Court over the delay in deciding a mercy petition that has been pending before the President since 2012.

“We have objection to what they are demanding. Considering the prevailing situation in the State [Punjab], it will not be condu-

cive to take any decision,” Additional Solicitor-General K.M. Nataraj, appearing for the Centre, told a Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath.

In view of the Centre’s opposition to the plea, the Bench, also comprising Justices Sandeep Mehta and Apresh Kumar Singh, said it would proceed to hear the matter on merits.

“Now that they insist on commuting their death sentence to life, which you oppose, we will hear the matter on merits,” the Bench said.

Youth groups issue joint call for Oct. 10 agitation

CJP says protest will continue till electoral system is 'reformed', urges youth to 'book tickets to Delhi'; Neha Bora says protest is a fight by 'we the people of India' against BJP to 'save democracy'

Suruchi Kumari
Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Youth organisations on Wednesday urged youngsters from across the country to join a protest on October 10 at Jantar Mantar in Delhi demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and a rollback of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The All India Students Association (AISA), the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), the All India Students' Federation (AISF), the Student Federation of India (SFI), and the Association of Students of Alternative Politics (ASAP) addressed a joint press conference here.

"The call of 10 October is a united call of the 'we the people of India' versus the BJP. The call is not by one organisation, it is by all of us - the CJP, INDIA opposition, and the student wings of all the opposition parties," said AISA president Neha Bora.

Ms. Bora said that while the protest over NEET irregularities in June ended



AISA leader Neha Bora, CJP leader Saurav Das, and others at the Press Club of India in New Delhi on Wednesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

with the resignation of a Cabinet Minister, Dharmendra Pradhan, this time it will lead to the CEC's ouster. "This is a fight to save democracy. We will not tolerate isolated detentions by the Delhi Police. All of us will come together when even one of us is threatened in the protest," she added.

Mr. Das reiterated that the CJP, along with all student organisations and civil society groups, will hit the streets on October 10 and go back only when the electoral system is reformed.

"We will not stop at the resignation of Gyanesh Kumar. We will have to ensure that people who take illegal decisions are arrested and (that) there are criminal proceedings against them. We will not stop till SIR is rolled back, the voter rolls are restored to January 2025 and (the) law to appoint the Election Commissioners is reformed," he said.

'Buy tickets to Delhi'
Giving the slogan of "Dilli Chalo", Mr. Das said, "People who have not booked their train tickets, they

should book their tickets of train or flights, or book a cab and come to Delhi. This is going to be a long fight to change the broken system. The right to vote is the only way to change the system, and to protect that, only youth can put up the fight. Only Gen Z can put up this fight. This is why the government is scared of us."

Mr. Das said that the government should initiate talks with the youth delegation about reforming the system instead of using force against the protesters.

"We have received information that the government is mobilising their extremist groups against us to derail the protest and create a hostile and violent atmosphere," he said.

Earlier in the day, Mr. Das formally intimidated the Delhi Police about the October 10 protest.

The police "acknowledged" the intimation letter, following which the organisers completed the paperwork and gave an undertaking in connection with the proposed demonstration. The police are yet to give a permission.

INDIA bloc yet to get an appointment with Murmu to raise concerns on ECI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The request by the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) for an appointment with President Droupadi Murmu to apprise her of its concerns over the functioning of the Election Commission of India (ECI) has so far drawn a blank.

The Opposition leaders had suggested that only a select delegation would meet the President, keeping in mind the protocol associated with the country's highest constitutional office, and had conveyed multiple dates for the meeting. However, according to sources, they are yet to receive any response from the President's office.

According to sources, INDIA bloc leaders suggested that the meeting be scheduled on either October 7, 8 or 9, providing sufficient notice for senior leaders to travel to Delhi. They proposed a 15-member delegation, with one representative from each of the grouping's top 15 constituent parties.

Sources said the President's office had informally conveyed that the delegation should be limited to



Hitting the streets: Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and others during a sit-in protest in New Delhi. PTI

10 members. The INDIA bloc leader coordinating with the President's Secretariat said the Opposition had agreed to this condition as well, but had still not heard from Ms. Murmu's office.

CPI(M) MP's letter

Meanwhile, a letter written by CPI(M) MP John Brittas to President Murmu on September 23 seeking urgent constitutional intervention in the ECI's special intensive revision (SIR) exercise, received a response on Wednesday.

In his letter, Mr. Brittas had sought the President's intervention on the SIR controversy, the unhindered progress of the

pending proceedings for the removal of the Chief Election Commissioner, and the Union government's support before the Supreme Court for declaring the SIR "void ab initio" and annulling it.

The President's Secretariat forwarded the petition to the Legislative Department and marked a copy to Mr. Brittas, describing the petition as "self-explanatory" and directing that the action taken be communicated to him. "The petition is self-explanatory. The constitutional questions it raises cannot be wished away. The only appropriate course now is for Gyanesh Kumar to quit forthwith," Mr. Brittas said.

Cong. slams 'manhandling' of Rahul and other MPs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Objecting to the manner in which the Delhi Police manhandled Opposition leaders, including Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, the Congress has called State units to observe black day and hold protests in the States on Thursday.

"Mr. Gandhi, our senior leaders and MPs of INDIA Bloc were brutally manhandled, lathi-charged and seriously injured. This assault on the Leader of the Opposition and the elected representatives of the people is an assault on the Constitution itself," a circular, issued by party leader K.C. Venugopal, read.

Can voters caught in tribunal cases be re-enrolled, Bengal CEO asks ECI

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) has requested the Election Commission of India (ECI) for clarity on whether voters whose cases are stuck in the State's Appellate Tribunals could in any manner be considered for the fresh re-enrolment drive of electors left out during the SIR process.

On October 2, the ECI had directed the CEOs of all States and Union Territories where the special intensive revision (SIR) has been completed or is under way to compare the pre-SIR voter lists with the current ones and enrol within a period of one month those whose have



The appellate tribunals have till now cleared 1.26 lakh out of total 38.31 lakh SIR appeals. PTI

been left out but are eligible, through Form 6.

At a meeting with the CEOs on Tuesday, the ECI asked them to proceed with the special enrolment drive on a war footing by holding camps to begin with and followed by door-to-door visits by the booth-

level officers (BLOs).

While many CEOs had queries on the time limit for the exercise and other protocols, the West Bengal CEO put up a query regarding whether the more than 38 lakh voters whose cases are stuck in appellate tribunals would be part of the drive, sources said.

'No clear answer'

A senior ECI official present at the videoconferencing could not give her a clear answer and told her that the matter would be discussed later. *The Hindu* had reported earlier that the ECI sources had said the new enrolment drive would not be applicable to the tribunal cases.

The appellate tribunals have till now cleared 1.26

lakh out of total 38.31 lakh appeals, which is approximately 3% of total cases.

Out of the 19 appellate tribunals set up by the ECI in March, only 16 remain functional as three retired judges have quit citing functional issues. Their positions remain vacant.

The appellate tribunals came out of the Supreme Court supervision of the SIR. Judicial officers, drawn from a list the Calcutta High Court sent at the Supreme Court's direction, were adjudicating the roughly 60 lakh "doubtful and pending" cases. On March 10, the court had directed that a separate appellate body be set up so that people could challenge those officers' decisions.

SC to examine plea on CEC appointment law split verdict

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday agreed to examine and take a call on hearing an application seeking to recall a split verdict pronounced on September 23 in a case challenging the Election Commissioners' appointments law.

The application, orally mentioned before Chief Justice of India Surya Kant by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, questions why one of the judges on the apex court Bench, Justice Satish Chandra Sharma, did not reveal during multiple court proceedings that his son was a standing counsel for the Election Commission of India (ECI).

The plea, filed by Naman Sherstra, has sought a recall of the opinion given by Justice Sharma, who was the puisne judge on the Division Bench headed by Justice Datta, on September 23 on the question of referring the challenge to the constitutional validity of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 to a five-judge Bench.

Differing views

While Justice Dipankar Datta, who was the lead judge on the Bench, in his opinion, had declined the reference to a Constitution Bench, Justice Sharma took an opposing view in favour of the reference.

Eventually, both judges on the Bench passed a common order for the CJI to allocate the case to a Constitution Bench.

The application has objected to this common order, but did not challenge, specifically, the separate opinion given by Justice Datta. Justice Datta had observed in his opinion that the 2023 law was *prima facie* wrong to ignore an earlier Constitution Bench judgment in the *Anoop Baranwal* case, which had included the CJI as a neutral member in the Prime Minister-led selection panel for Chief Election Commissioners (CECs) and Election Commissioners (ECs).

The 2023 law had replaced the CJI with a Union Minister nominated by the Prime Minister.

SC declines Bengal plea against bail for Cong. leader

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday refused to interfere with a Calcutta High Court decision granting interim bail to Congress Nandigram Assembly byelection candidate Milan Pradhan a day after the polling.

A Bench of the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice V. Mohana disposed of the State of West Bengal's challenge to the High Court order.

The Bench did not comment on the merits of the cases registered against Mr. Pradhan. It said the State was free to raise all contentions against Mr. Pradhan in the appropriate court if he seeks an extension of interim bail or regular bail.

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta told the court that Mr. Pradhan had to surrender on October 21.

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY e-Tender Notice
Tender No: 05/2026 - 27/PPD/TVM Others - Grey Water Reuse - 15 MLD Tertiary Treatment Plant at Muttathara - Design, Engineering, Procurement, Construction, Erection, Commissioning and Operation & Maintenance for a period of 5 years after successful commissioning of 15 MLD Treatment Plant for Tertiary Treatment of Sewage Effluent at STP Muttathara, Thiruvananthapuram, EMD: Rs. 5,00,000/, Tender Fee : Rs. 16,540 + 18% GST, Last Date for Submitting Tender : 02.11.2026, 03:00 pm, Phone: 8547638425.
Website : www.kwa.kerala.gov.in, www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
Thiruvananthapuram
KWA-JB-GL-6-340-2026-27
Superintending Engineer
PPD Regional Office

OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR, STATE FORENSIC SCIENCE LABORATORY, RAJASTHAN NEHRU NAGAR, JAIPUR-302016
क्रमांक- स. 10 (1) सेवे- स्टोर / ई - निविद-02 / 2026-27 दिनांक 28.09.2026
E BID INVITING NOTICE-02/2026-27
Bids for 1 years Rate contracts of different Consumable Chemicals, Glasswares, general lab items etc., of total estimated value INR 1200.00 lakhs are invited from interested bidders up to 6.00 PM on 21-10-2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> or <https://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>) of the state.

S.N.	Name of Item	UBN NO.	Approx. Cost (in Lakhs)
1	1(A).Chemicals	FSL2627GLRC00035	75.00
	1(B). Chemicals	FSL2627GLRC00036	60.00
	1(C). Chemicals	FSL2627GLRC00037	35.00
	1(D).Toxicology snake venom kit	FSL2627GLRC00038	15.00
2	2(A)Glassware	FSL2627GLRC00039	20.00
	2(B) Glassware (Fabricated)	FSL2627GLRC00040	9.00
3	General Plastic ware	FSL2627GLRC00041	30.00
4	4 (A)Consumables For Instruments	FSL2627GLRC00042	15.00
	4 (B) Consumables For Instruments (Toxi-I)	FSL2627GLRC00043	18.00
	4 (C) Consumables For Instruments (Toxi-2)	FSL2627GLRC00044	5.00
	4 (D) General Laboratory Items-I	FSL2627GLRC00045	15.00
	4 (E) General Laboratory Items-II	FSL2627GLRC00046	8.00
5	Crime Scene Kit Consumables/ Items	FSL2627GLRC00047	45.00
6	Gases used in Analysis & Instrumentation	FSL2627GLRC00048	10.00
7	Photo Material For Photo Division	FSL2627GLRC00049	20.00
8	8(a) Kits and consumables material required for DNA Examination	FSL2627GLRC00050	800.00
	8(b) Antisera & Blood Detection Reagent	FSL2627GLRC00051	20.00

Head of the Office
State Forensic Science Laboratory, Rajasthan, Jaipur

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, संभाग-भरतपुर
क्रमांक: ए.सी.ई./जे.टी.पी/निविद/2026-26/ई-1193 दिनांक 25/9/2026
निविदा सूचना संख्या : 15/2026-27
राजस्थान के राजपूत महेन्द्र जी और से भरतपुर संभाग के अर्लीन जिला भरतपुर, डीए एवं टीएलए में सड़क निर्माण कार्य के लिए अत्युक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग में पंजीकृत संवेदकों एवं राज्य सरकार / केन्द्रीय सरकार के अधिकृत संगठनों / केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण विभाग / डाक एवं दूर संचार विभाग / रेलवे इत्यादि में पंजीकृत संवेदकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के विभिन्न सक्षम श्रेणी के संवेदकों के समकक्ष हो, से निविदित प्रपत्र में ई-प्रोक्चरमेंट प्रक्रिया हेतु ऑन लाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।
निविदा से संबंधित समस्त विवरण वेबसाईट ["www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in"](http://www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in) एवं ["www.sppp.raj.nic.in"](http://www.sppp.raj.nic.in) पर देखा जा सकता है। इच्छुक संवेदकों को अपने डिजिटल हस्ताक्षर के माध्यम से वेबसाईट ["www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in"](http://www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in) पर रजिस्टर करवाना आवश्यक है।
NIB-PWD2627A2970
UBN-PWD2627WLOB13385
UBN-PWD2627WLOB13386
UBN-PWD2627WSOB13388
UBN-PWD2627WSOB13390
UBN-PWD2627WSOB13391
DIPR/C/16930/2026

Office of Additional Chief Engineer PHED, Region Bharatpur
Telephone No 05644-221500, Email: rj_acebha@nic.in
No. F(ACE)/BPR/2026-27/5363-83 Date: 29-09-2026
Notice Inviting Bid No. 18/2026-27
Online bids for NIB No. 18/2026-27 (01 work), Costing Rs. 609.96 Lacs is invited on behalf of the Government of Rajasthan from eligible enlisted in appropriate class contractors of PHED, Rajasthan and meeting eligibility criteria. Contractors enlisted with other departments of Government of Rajasthan and enlisted with CPWD/ Postal/ Telecom/ Railways/ MES/ other State Government/ Central Government undertakings/ organization in class equivalent to "A/AA" class of Rajasthan (as applicable) and meeting prescribed eligibility criteria may also apply. Details of this Bid notification and pre-qualification criteria can also be seen in NIB exhibited on web site www.dipr.rajjasthan.gov.in, <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in> and <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>. Bids are to be submitted online electronic format on web site <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> up to 26-10-2026 (6PM) & Bids are to be opened at 03.00 PM on 27-10-2026.
NIB Code : PHE2627A2857
UBN No. : PHE2627WLOB06042
Mohan Lal Meena
Addl. Chief Engineer
PHED, Region Bharatpur
DIPR/C/17043/2026

सी डेक Centre for Development
CDAC of Advanced Computing
Expression of Interest (Eoi)
Expression of Interest is sought from Indian Companies for Acquiring Technology from CDAC for "Autonomous Bathymetric Survey Vessel (ABSV) with Advanced Glacial Lake Profiling Suite & Advanced Water Quality Sensor Suite".
For details visit ["www.cdac.in"](http://www.cdac.in), Contact: 0471 2723333, 9847069184, tpc@cdac.in

APPOINTMENT
ANDHRA UNIVERSITY VISAKHAPATNAM, ANDHRAPRADESH, INDIA
MAAC- Accredited "A" Grade with a CGPA of 3.74 out of four point scale "ISO 9001 : 2015 Certified"
PDF NOTIFICATION
Applications in the prescribed proforma are invited for the Posts of AU Centenary Post Doctoral Fellows, in Department of History & Archaeology (01), Department of Geo-Engineering (01), Department of Geology (01), Department of Law (02), Department of Microbiology (01), Department of Psychology (01), Department of Quantum Technology (02), Department of Semi-Conductor (01), Andhra University, Visakhapatnam.
Issue of Notification : 08-10-2026 | Last date for Receipt of Application : 24-10-2026
The prescribed application form, qualifications, scales of pay attached to the post etc., registration fee and other details can be had from the University website : www.andhrauniversity.edu.in
The last date for receipt of the duly filled in application is : 24-10-2026
The University reserves the right to fill or not to fill any of the post(s) without giving any reason whatsoever.
Date: 08-10-2026 Sd/-Registrar

MAHATRANSCO
Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.
NOTICE INVITING TENDER CPD/55-2026-27
Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:

Tender No. & Description of Material	Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs) Tender Fee (in Rs.)	Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
SP/T-0514/1026 [RFx 5000001621] 2nd Call for Procurement of 50MVA, 132-110/33kV (05 No.) Power Transformers along with New Uninhibited High Grade Mineral Insulating Oil for Karad Zone of MSETCL.	4499.79 25,000.00	16.10.2026 17.00 Hrs 16.10.2026 17.15 Hrs.
Pre-Bid Queries to be addressed to MSETCL, "Prakashgad", Bandra (E), Mumbai	On or Before 09.10.2026	Time @18:15 Hrs.

Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (Gr-V) CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai
Tel. No.: 022-69852717/ 69852720. **Email id:** cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eegrp5@mahatransco.in, eeepc@mahatransco.in.
For further details visit our website <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/>.
Any further amendments/clarifications will be published on the MSETCL website www.mahatransco.in & <https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/>.
Bidders are therefore requested to check these websites for further updates.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (P&C)

INBRIEF



Two cheetahs released into M.P.'s third conservation site

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav released two cheetahs in the Veerangana Durgavati Tiger Reserve in Sagar district on Wednesday, marking the expansion of the cheetah conservation project. He said it was a historic day for wildlife in Madhya Pradesh, adding that the cats have been named Vyom and Neera. After Kuno National Park in Sheopur district and Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary in Mandsaur, the tiger reserve in the Bundelkhand region will be the third cheetah habitat. He also released the Vulture Population Estimation 2026 report and the book *Veerangana Durgavati Tiger Reserve*. PTI

4 students die while cleaning water tank at U.P. gurukul

Four students died and another suffered injuries after being exposed to suspected toxic gas while they were trying to clean an underground water tank at a gurukul in Mathura district of Uttar Pradesh on Wednesday. Mathura police said: “We were informed that a water tank in Vrindavan Gurukulam was smelling and the students entered it to clean it. The first boy to enter failed to emerge and four more followed him. They too failed to come out and bystanders had to rescue them. They were taken to hospital where four of the five have died.”

SC pulls up MCD, ASI over heritage sites’ preservation

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday pulled up the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) for their “total lackadaisical approach” to tackling widespread encroachments and ensuring the preservation of notified heritage structures in the Capital.

“We find a total lackadaisical approach by the authorities in either assisting the court commissioner or acting in a manner which would indicate that they are serious about what they implement on the ground. Matters ranging from keeping the sites free of encroachment, their cleanliness, details with regard to ownership, settlement, and the current position are not forthcoming. Even the authorities are blissfully ignorant of such details,” a Bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and N. Kotiswar Singh said.

The observations came while the top court was hearing a petition filed by Delhi resident Rajeev Suri concerning the preservation and restoration of heritage sites across Delhi.

SC flags accessibility gaps in aviation infrastructure

Court issues notice to AAI, Central Industrial Security Force, and the Digi Yatra Foundation on plea highlighting ‘systemic failure’ to implement accessibility initiatives to aid persons with disabilities

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday decided to ask the Union government why millions of passengers with disabilities continue to face humiliation, barriers, broken equipment, and digital exclusion in one of the world’s fastest-growing aviation markets.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant issued formal notice to the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation, the Airports Authority of India, the Central Industrial Security Force, and the Digi Yatra Foundation on a petition filed by Turab Chimthanawala, a company secretary and advocate based in Mumbai, who suffers a benchmark disability called Leber’s Congenital Amaurosis.

Advocate Ashutosh Senger, for Mr. Chimthanawala, submitted that India was at present the third largest aviation market globally, with annual passenger traffic exceeding 350



Access barrier: Silent airports fail to provide alternative modes of communication for disabled people, the plea said. SUDHAKARA JAIN

million passengers. Yet, persons with disabilities face denial of accessible aviation infrastructure and services, restricting their fundamental right to travel independently and with dignity.

“Domestic passenger traffic has consistently grown at approximately 10-12% annually over the past decade. Even based on the conservative estimate of 2.21% disability prevalence recorded in the Census of 2011, this translates to over seven million air passengers with disabilities annually... The magnitude of affected persons underscores the systemic and na-

tional scale of the accessibility failure,” Mr. Senger submitted. The petition referred to recent media reports of a wheelchair-dependent passenger who was allegedly offloaded in Delhi while connecting from a Frankfurt flight.

Systemic gaps

The plea highlighted a systemic and nationwide failure of non-implementation of accessibility initiatives across all stages of air travel. These include instances of passengers with visual disabilities routinely forced into wheelchairs or being frequently compelled to use special-

ised ambulifts even when they can safely use regular staircases. In-flight systems fail to incorporate accessibility settings, leaving visually challenged passengers unable to call cabin crew or access basic safety information on foreign scheduled air transport services.

Silent airports fail to provide accessible alternative modes of communication for persons with disabilities, including real-time audio notifications, visual alerts, or WhatsApp updates, the petition said. Besides, airline mobile applications and booking websites systematically fail to support screen readers, lack compatible payment gateways for assistive technology, and omit mandatory options to disclose disability-related assistance requirements during check-in.

Further, airlines do not provide dedicated, clearly identifiable feedback or grievance mechanisms for reporting accessibility barriers, forcing disabled travellers into generic customer support queues, it said.

Delhi govt. plan to revamp new flyover amid traffic snarls

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The constant traffic snarls on the newly opened Barapullah Phase-III flyover have prompted the Delhi government to consider integrating the corridor with surrounding roads.

Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Wednesday said a joint assessment by his department and Delhi Traffic Police had identified the merger point where traffic from different directions is funnelled into fewer lanes as a key area requiring intervention. He said the PWD is examining a dedicated U-turn or diversion on Ring Road near Shree Bala Sahib Ji Gurdwara to provide residents of Siddhartha Extension direct access to the approach road towards INA and AIIMS.

The proposed U-turn aims to reduce unnecessary diversions and prevent local traffic from conflicting with vehicles using the main corridor, the Minister said.

The government also plans to appoint a traffic and structural design consultant to undertake a comprehensive assessment of the corridor and recommend interventions.

Centre eases access to defence testing facilities for companies, waives charges for key projects

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh has approved a revised Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for utilisation of Defence Ministry proof ranges, field firing ranges, and laboratory testing facilities by the Indian defence industry, with proof and testing charges waived for several government-backed developmental projects.

According to the Defence Ministry, the revised SOP aims to simplify and streamline access to testing infrastructure for indigenous defence companies, start-ups and innovators, and is expected to support the government’s push for “*atmanirbharta*” (self-reliance) in defence, innovation and defence exports.

Under the revised pro-



Rajnath Singh

cedure, proof and testing charges have been waived for iDEX, Technology Development Fund (TDF), Make and other developmental projects of the Defence Ministry.

A three-day slot every quarter has also been reserved at proof ranges for proof firing of government-sponsored developmental projects, including iDEX, TDF and Make projects.

The reserved slots will also cover developmental projects undertaken by in-

digenous defence firms on their own initiative, according to the revised SOP.

The SOP provides a list of proof ranges, field firing ranges and laboratory test facilities available with the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), Government Quality Assurance agencies and the three Services for use by Indian defence companies.

The revised SOP intends to simplify documentation and make the process more transparent and predictable for industry.

Another significant change is the replacement of the arbitration provision in the existing SOP with a conciliation agreement clause to facilitate faster resolution of issues that may arise between the industry and the authorities while using the testing and proof facilities.

Tipra Motha chief Pradyot Debbarma quits active politics

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Pradyot Kishore Manikya Debbarma, Tripura’s royal scion and founder of TIPRA Motha Party (TMP), a partner in the Bharatiya Janata Party-led government in the State, quit active politics on Wednesday.

His announcement came a day after the TMP registered a decisive victory in the Village Committee elections of the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council (TTAADC). TIPRA is short for Tipraha Indigenous Progressive Regional Alliance.

“Today, after much thought and considerable pain, I am making a clear and final decision. I am stepping away from active politics. I will no longer hold political office or participate in day-to-day political activity,” he wrote in a letter addressed to the peo-



Pradyot Debbarma

ple of Tripura. He said the decision was not a temporary withdrawal but a deeply personal choice made after years of service and reflection.

“I know what I am leaving behind. But I also know that I have reached a point where I must choose my health, my family and my own peace of mind,” he wrote.

Mr. Debbarma founded the TMP in 2019, soon after resigning as the State president of the Congress.

Bankers’ committees asked to report share of SC beneficiaries in jobs, loan subsidy schemes

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The Finance Ministry has directed State-level and Union Territory-level bankers’ committees to mandatorily include data on the percentage share of Scheduled Caste beneficiaries availing flagship Central schemes.

This direction comes after the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) flagged the fact that these bankers’ committees were not reporting these data for a number of government schemes in their regular reviews, which was hindering the Commission’s ability to perform its constitutional duties.

In a letter dated October 5, the Department of Financial Services (DFS) of the Union Finance Ministry wrote to all State-Level Bankers’ Committees

(SLBCs) and Union Territory-Level Bankers’ Committees (UTLBCs), asking them to include the percentage of SC beneficiaries for all the schemes flagged by the NCSC in their periodic reviews – both scheme-wise and bank-wise. The advisory also asked the bankers’ committees to ensure that this information is shared regularly with the Commission.

Review meetings

About a week ago, the NCSC had written to Sanjay Lohia, the Secretary of the DFS, highlighting that in review meetings of the bankers’ committees, SLBC Conveners do not reflect the percentage of SC beneficiaries for several schemes meant to ensure financial inclusion of citizens.

The NCSC had noted that such data were mis-

sing for the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana, Stand-Up India, Prime Minister’s Employment Generation Programme, PM SVANidhi (Street Vendors’ scheme), Credit Guarantee Fund Trust for Micro and Small Enterprises, and MSME business loans.

Sources aware of these developments told *The Hindu* that in reviewing the banks’ performance, the Commission routinely checks whether the share of SC beneficiaries in these government schemes is as close as possible to the share of their communities in the population. “This has not been possible for the Commission in recent times,” one government official said.

The DFS has now asked all SLBCs and UTLBCs to submit an action-taken report on the advisory issued to them by October 9.

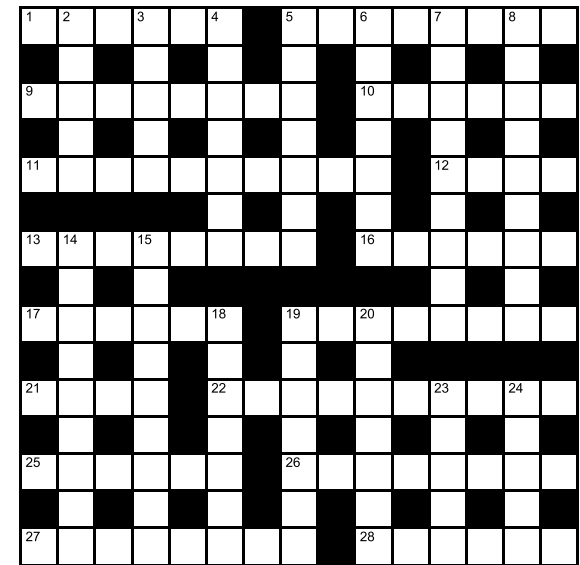
THE HINDU

CROSSWORD+ 14918

(Set by Pixie Dust)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- Across**
- American churchman not beginning to bother about country (6)
 - It's believed that swallow modelled (8)
 - Can these men of letters recreate real Titanic? (8)
 - South African animal delivered brand of footwear (6)
 - Toss a coin up umpteen times for a delicious beverage? (10)
 - Leonidas regularly missing targets (4)

- Day and night, say, Santo cycling around city Male (8)
 - Bogus Dame? (4-2)
 - Prompt understanding for those in hearing (6)
 - Doctor has decks, one makes payments here (4,4)
 - Mother India from east or west (4)
 - Avoid skirt (10)
 - Husband! Kiss and cuddle, mother's away for errand basically (3,3)
 - Tiro Quoiist protecting a member of a former confederacy (8)
 - Used card all over the place and struggled (8)
 - Spooner suggests: "Caress Sprite for a generous package!" (3,3)
- Down**
- For starters, radish and Italian tomatoes added in a yogurt-based dish (5)
 - Some scrape elbows back-to-front and make a high-pitched sound (5)
 - A new year welcoming playful pandemonium (7)
 - Strong drinks for ghosts (7)
 - Represent each type (7)
 - Penned ode about something that is unrestricted? (4-5)
 - Old rum I'd so let loose in opening remarks (9)
 - One who never lets cancer stick near? (3-6)
 - First sign of orphan Pirrip, say, with Spark? Almost magnificent! (9)
 - In a panic mentioned tailing former boyfriend (7)
 - Moved, shed tears over Army Regulation (7)
 - Disconnect appliances which you want to babyproof yourself at last (4,3)
 - Clear the cellar (5)
 - Currency found in Malaysian AirAsia (5)

SUDOKU

4			8					9
	9				7		8	6
						5	4	
		9	4				5	8
			9	6	2			
6	4				5	2		
	7	5						
9	1		2				7	
3				9				5

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

As GST council meets today, tax specialists look for reforms beyond rates

"A unified approach to issues that cuts across State lines would curb duplicative information requests and eliminate the risk of divergent conclusions on the same transaction," Mr. Vijaivergia said.

This could include payments for subscriptions to television channels, apps, journals or newspapers.

Also, telecom operators stoutly resisted “administrative assignment” of satellite spectrum, entailing Starlink and other operators to use airwaves for fixed fee instead of taking part in an auction. Since satellite spectrum is shared without issue in most countries, Reliance Jio has argued the 2012 2G spectrum judgment of the Supreme Court prohibits such an assignment.

Benefit from Carbfix

U.S. woman who survived botched execution is conscious, speaking



Hezbollah gets \$200 mn from Iran to help displaced by this year's war



U.S. Army in Okinawa faces curfew and alcohol ban after murder case



Nepal to amend laws to facilitate death registration of those missing



CM
YK

Shreyas soars to seventh in T20Is, Gill remains No.1 ODI batter



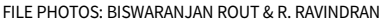
Laxman will attend selection committee meetings, says Saikia



I owe Messi a debt of eternal gratitude, says coach Scaloni



Bhagat and Bhavina to be India's flag-bearers at Asian Para Games



I am not pushed enough: Vithya

The world stands still as Messi signs off on a perfect note

APL second season gets underway today

Smriti Mandhana, India's new captain, has earned her job

History will be kinder to you: Gambhir to Agarkar



For Indian table tennis, Manush and Diya's was the fourth medal at the Asian Games and ensured that the sport had a podium finish for a third consecutive time

Amol Karhadkar

For four days in early September, Manush Shah travelled to Mumbai, the hometown of his mixed doubles partner Diya Chitale for a relatively simple job. Train. There were no selection meetings to worry about, no administrative developments to follow, no uncertainty over who would be around the Indian table tennis team. In Mumbai, the pair could concentrate on the one thing that had brought them together in the first place – making their partnership work. Those four days would prove valuable when they eventually arrived in Aichi-Nagoya. The sixth-seeded Indian pair went on to win a bronze medal at the Asian Games, beating Hong Kong's third-seeded Wong Chun Ting and Doo Hoi Kem in the quarterfinals before losing to eventual silver medallists Wong Chuqin and Sun Yingsha of China in the semifinals.

Significant achievement For Indian table tennis, the medal was significant. It was the fourth at the Asian Games and ensured that the sport had a podium finish at a third successive edition of the continental extravaganza. For Manush and Diya, though, the bronze represented something more personal. It was the reward for a

partnership that had steadily climbed the international ladder and, in the process, had learnt to complement two very different games. It was also an affirmation that, amid a turbulent build-up, they had managed to keep the noise away from the table. When Diya spoke about going into her second Asian Games, she did not need to be reminded of the difference between a regular international tournament and a multi-sport event. Her first Asian Games, in Hangzhou three years ago, had given her that perspective. "Going into my second Asian Games, I think the first one gave me a lot of experience and exposure," Diya told *The Hindu* before leaving for Japan. "Representing the country at a multi-sport event is a very different feeling. It was a great experience in 2023, and I wanted to carry that experience forward." But there was a difference this time. The expectations were higher. Diya and Manush were no longer simply an emerging combination hoping to make an impression. They had become one of India's principal medal contenders, their progress reflected by a place among the world's top-eight pairs at the 2025 WTT Finals, the season-ending event reserved for the leading performers of the year. "We have been doing really well in doubles," Diya had said ahead of the Games. "Me and Manush have been doing really, really well for the last two or three years. When we started, our graph has gone up a lot."

That graph eventually took them to an Asian Games podium. The bronze did not arrive out of nowhere. Over the preceding seasons, the pair had learnt the demands of international mixed doubles, where the rhythm and speed of a rally can differ considerably from men's doubles.

Breaking it down Manush described the distinction in simple terms. "In men's doubles, you expect power from the opponents. The ball really travels and you expect good quality, so you don't have to manage the front-and-back movement as much," he said. "In mixed doubles, it is the opposite. The front-and-back movement becomes really important because the woman on the opposing pair may not be as powerful. They try to play quickly, so the ball can be a little slower and you have to make faster adjustments with your footwork." That difference requires more than just technical ability. It requires trust. "In mixed doubles, Diya is the one with the control and I try to finish the point," Manush said. "If this works out, then we are already one step ahead of the opponent. That is what the goal is all about in doubles." The quarterfinal against Hong Kong was evidence of that equation working when it mattered. India's table tennis contingent had not arrived at Aichi-Nagoya without precedent. In 2018, the men's team won a historic bronze and Sharath Kamal and Manika Batra added another bronze in mixed doubles. In

Hangzhou, Ayhika Mukherjee and Sutirtha Mukherjee produced a surprise run to the women's doubles bronze. Manush and Diya's medal therefore extended the sequence of Indian table tennis appearing on the Asian Games podium. Yet it carried a different weight. Unlike the Hangzhou women's doubles bronze, which came as a surprise, this was a medal India had begun to expect from the pair. Their qualification for the WTT Finals in 2025 had placed them among the world's leading combinations, while their performances over the preceding couple of seasons had made them a credible medal proposition. "Since two or three years, we have been doing really well," Diya had said. "We understand each other's game better now. We know each other's strengths and weaknesses."

That understanding had been tested against the world's best. "We have played a lot of top pairs over the years," she said. "We have beaten a top Japanese pair and qualified for the WTT Finals, where the top eight pairs in the world play. All these experiences put together have helped us reach where we are today." The Asian Games simply provided the biggest stage yet on which that accumulated experience had to translate into a result. And it did. The achievement becomes more significant when the build-up to the Asian Games is considered. Indian table tennis spent much of the preceding months dealing with issues away from the playing arena. The selection controversy surrounding Manika Batra had cast a shadow over the process after she was left out of the Asian Games squad for failing to meet the prescribed selection criteria. The episode led to questions about the transparency of the selection system and public exchanges between the paddler and the federation.

Then, in August, the Sports Ministry suspended the recognition of the Table Tennis Federation of India as the National Sports Federation for table tennis, citing a series of administrative and governance issues. The turmoil had consequences beyond the boardroom. Massimo Costantini's tenure as India's foreign expert had expired on May 15, and the uncertainty surrounding the federation meant his continuation with the national set-up was delayed. The Italian eventually joined the Indian contingent in Japan only a week before the Asian Games. Against that backdrop, Manush and Diya had little choice but to concentrate on what they could control.

Rising expectations There was no luxury of an extended camp dedicated exclusively to the mixed doubles combination. The international calendar rarely allows it. But the partnership had already developed enough understanding to make those sessions count. Diya was aware before the Games that expectations would follow them. The pair's rise had ensured that. "Pressure is always going to be there," she had said. "There will always be some expectations and some pressure. But what is important is that we gave our best and are happy with the way it

progressed." That attitude became particularly relevant in the quarterfinal. A defeat would have meant another near-miss for Indian table tennis. A victory would guarantee at least a bronze. Manush and Diya delivered. The win over Wong and Doo, seeded third, confirmed the medal and effectively transformed their status from contenders to medallists. The bronze was secure. While Manush has come a long way since starting to train under Shailesh Gosain's watchful eyes in Vadodra, Diya has been coached by Sachin Shetty ever since she took up the sport more than a decade and a half ago. Since their junior days, Olympic Gold Quest has been supporting the duo's journey towards excellence in the international circuit. Government support has also reduced some of the financial pressure on athletes and their families. "With so many government schemes, the Government helps a lot with the TOPS scheme," Diya said. "Of course, that also relieves the financial pressure on the parents." That support becomes especially relevant when an athlete is required to travel extensively, train continuously and compete against the world's best. By the time Diya and Manush stepped onto the Asian Games arena, they were carrying the work of that entire ecosystem with them. More than just a bronze. The significance of the medal extends beyond the result of one quarterfinal and one semifinal.

Bigger message It means India has now won table tennis medals at three consecutive Asian Games. It means the country has a established mixed doubles combination capable of competing with the best in Asia. And it confirms that Manush and Diya's journey from promising partnership to world-class combination has been real. Their qualification for the 2025 WTT Finals had already indicated where they belonged. The Asian Games provided a different kind of test – one where the draw, the occasion and the weight of expectations all mattered. They responded by beating the third seeds and securing India's only table tennis medal at the Games. The loss to the Chinese pair in the semifinal did not diminish what had been achieved. If anything, it reinforced the progression. Three years earlier, Diya had entered her first Asian Games looking for experience and exposure while Manush had endured the disappointment of being one point away from a medal in men's doubles. This time they went for a medal. "We went into the Asian Games aiming for a medal," Diya said. "And we are thrilled that we have achieved the objective and have brought that medal home".

THE GIST

For Manush and Diya, though, the bronze represented something more personal. It was the reward for a partnership that had steadily climbed the international ladder and, in the process, had learnt to complement two very different games

When the two stepped onto the Asian Games arena, they were carrying the work of an ecosystem with them. The significance of the medal extended beyond the result of one quarterfinal and one semifinal

Three years earlier, Diya had entered her first Asian Games looking for experience and exposure while Manush had endured the disappointment of being one point away from a medal in men's doubles. This time they went for a medal, and got it



SCIENCE

India’s cement footprint stands in its way to net-zero emissions

Producing cement is highly carbon-intensive and releases greenhouse gases as part of limestone calcination processes; extracting limestone also destroys forests and fertile topsoil; cement is so entrenched in modern construction that the sector remains exceptionally hard to abate

Monika Mondal
BERLIN

By 2047, India plans to become an economically developed country. By 2070, it aims at becoming a net-zero emissions economy. Achieving both of these targets requires the Indian government to deal with one of the most important sources of emissions: construction.

This sector consumes steel and cement, among other materials, and its footprint contributes 35% to 40% of all greenhouse gas emissions around the world.

Most of these emissions are because of the energy that the steel and cement sectors need to reach extremely high temperatures required for industrial processes. But even between the two, the cement sector also emits carbon when calcinating limestone — a chemical reaction that makes cement one of the few hard-to-abate sectors, and which contributes 7 to 11% of emissions, almost double that of the aviation sector.

Need for cement

Construction activities have been part of human civilisation for many centuries. Cement became the standard binding agent only in the 19th century, with the development of Portland cement in Britain in the 1820s, when builders were trying to meet the demands of rapid industrialisation. Before that, people used mineral-based binders, the material that holds bricks, sand, and stone together.

“Traditionally, India and many other parts of the world used a much wider range of binders and construction systems than Portland cement,” Nandini Halder, assistant professor at the School of Architecture and Planning, Vishwakarma University, Pune, said. “These included lime-based mortars, lime-surkhi mortars, mud/clay mortars, gypsum-based materials, and, in some contexts, naturally pozzolanic materials.”

(A pozzolanic material reacts with calcium hydroxide in water to form cementitious compounds, thus strengthening concrete without itself being cement.)

Researchers have suggested that meeting India’s infrastructure and housing demands may not be realistic without cement. However, that does not mean there are no alternatives. The Taj Mahal, which was completed in the mid-17th century, is testimony to the efficacy of lime mortar. Many Roman buildings until the 4th century AD that used lime-based binders with volcanic pozzolanic materials also still stand.

“The issue is less about the technologies having disappeared and more about the construction industry having developed an enormous ecosystem around cement,” Ms. Halder noted.

“One of the challenges is that cement has become deeply embedded in the construction industry through standardisation, commercial availability, established supply chains, building practices and extensive marketing. Traditional materials often lack the same level of commercial infrastructure and standardised supply.”

Science of cement

“Not just cement production ... [The] wider life cycle of cement and concrete has an environmental impact. From extraction and processing of raw materials, subsequent manufacturing, and transportation to construction sites,” Dr. Halder added.

Limestone — the raw material for cement — is formed when calcium-rich marine life, such as oysters and corals, is fossilised and compressed over millions of years.

Accessing it requires miners to first clear forests and all layers of fertile soil in specific areas to expose the sedimentary rock layer. Depending on the geography, limestone can be found 30 to 60 meters under the topsoil in Karnataka, Chhattisgarh, and Andhra Pradesh and at more shallow depths in Rajasthan.

Once that limestone is brought to a factory, it is mixed with clay and heated to around 1,450 degree Celsius. This heating process alone accounts for 35% to 40% of emissions from cement-making; the rest comes from the chemical breakdown of limestone.

When limestone is heated in the calcination process, it releases carbon dioxide as a by-product along with small stone-like balls called clinkers. These clinkers, responsible for 53% to 65% of emissions, are made of calcium silicates, calcium aluminates, and calcium aluminoferrites. They are crushed into powder and mixed in several ratios with gypsum and fly ash and sold as the various cement types available on the market.

India’s cement industry currently emits 0.62 tonnes (or 620 kg) of carbon dioxide per tonne of cement. In a decarbonisation roadmap prepared with the Global Cement and Concrete Association, experts from The



Green construction: Traditional ordinary Portland cement consists of over 95% clinker mixed with gypsum. GOWTHAM AGM/UNSPASH

Energy and Resources Institute, New Delhi, said India should aim to reduce the emission rate to 0.56 tonnes of carbon dioxide tonne of cement made by 2030 and to 0.51 tonnes of carbon dioxide by 2047.

The same report also estimated cement production in India is expected to rise from 334 million tonnes in 2019- 20 to 1,546 million tonnes in 2070.

But “carbon dioxide is not the only environmental concern associated with industrial activity,” Ms. Halder said. “Cement manufacturing can also be associated with air pollutants such as nitrogen oxides, sulphur dioxide and particulate matter. These should be distinguished from greenhouse gases, which are assessed using their global warming potential.”

There are also many “hidden” sources of carbon. Some examples are the carbon cost of cutting down hills to secure the limestone, emissions due to long distance transport, and the long-term effects of the loss of vegetation and the corresponding loss of carbon sequestration. And these effects are not typically considered in discussions around the cement industry.

“The dialogue on the effects before and after the cement production units are under-emphasised in current climate debates” in India, Kaveri Ashok, a researcher at the Center for Study of Science, Technology and Policy, Bengaluru, said.

Existing and proposed solutions

Since the dawn of the First Industrial Revolution, engineers and manufacturers have used coal, petroleum coke or natural gas to heat kilns. Today, with the focus on renewable sources of energy, electrification and the use of solid municipal waste to produce refuse-derived fuel (RDF) — to replace coal as a heat source for kilns — are at the forefront, according to a decarbonisation roadmap that NITI Aayog, the Indian government’s topmost think-tank.

RDF is processed waste, typically shredded and sorted, with combustible materials concentrated into a fuel suitable for industrial boilers and cement kilns.

Before Portland cement, India and many other parts of the world used a wider range of construction binders like lime, lime-surkhi, mud/clay, gypsum, and natural pozzolanic binders

The idea is especially attractive because it also creates an incentive to improve waste management.

The NITI Aayog roadmap recommends that India “increase the use of RDF from municipal solid waste to achieve a 20% thermal substitution rate by 2030”, resulting in “a cumulative emission reduction of approximately 80 million tonnes of carbon-dioxide-equivalent”. But this requires India to do a better job of segregating waste at the source.

Another option focuses on reducing the amount of clinker: by mixing it with waste or by-products like slag from heavy industries like power plants and steelmaking. The less clinker cement contains, the greener it is. According to the International Energy Agency, replacing one tonne of clinker can avoid 0.83 tonnes of carbon dioxide emissions.

This said, cement cannot be fully decarbonised, so attaining net-zero emissions makes carbon capture inevitable.

The substitution also presents another limit: “While there are options where substitution goes as high as 50-70%, [in practice] the average substitution cannot be more than 40%” Ms. Ashok added, or a building’s integrity could suffer. This is why cement “is called hard-to-abate”.

Traditional ordinary Portland cement (OPC) consists of over 95% clinker mixed with gypsum. Portland pozzolana cement has 65-80% of clinker with fly ash and gypsum. Portland slag cement consists of 35-64% of clinker, with the rest a mixture of gypsum and granulated slag from a blast furnace. But per Ms. Ashok, real-estate developers and builders generally prefer OPC. One reason is that while all three types

have a similar setting time of around 30 minutes, OPC gains strength in one week while the other two could take twice as long.

“To push the demand for green cement in the initial few years, maybe the government can do more public procurement of green cement,” she suggested.

Since green cement replaces clinker with waste from other industries, it is less expensive. As per NITI Aayog, clinker-to-cement ratio — around 67.5% — in India is already lower than the global average of 77% and can be further reduced.

Some researchers are also working on complementary solutions like using traditional materials to make binders and to design buildings better. Then there is also the challenge of changing people’s perceptions about the alternatives.

“Cement is easy to use, relatively fast-setting, versatile and widely understood by the construction industry. It can be used in a very wide range of structural and architectural applications, and the existing construction ecosystem is built around it,” Ms. Halder said. “These factors make cement very difficult to replace at scale, even when we recognise its environmental impact.”

Looking beyond cement

In her research, Arpita Mathur, assistant professor at the National Institute of Construction Management and Research, Pune, has been studying indigenous construction practices. She said that depending on the requirements, there are several examples of alternatives to conventional cement-based construction around India, each of which evolved in response to the local geography and weather. For example, in Southern India, compressed earth blocks and rammed earth have been used with soil and sand and relatively small amounts of cement or lime.

Ms. Mathur has also identified binding agents such as cactus juice — a thick water-repellant fluid derived from cactus plants and mixed with lime and mud — and marble powder, a by-product of the marble industry.

Traditional Kath Kuni construction in Himachal Pradesh uses dry masonry and alternating layers of wooden beams without cement, with the structure using a raised stone plinth for better strength. In parts of Northern and Northeastern India, houses are raised above the ground using lightweight wood and bamboo to better survive flooding and earthquakes.

But these options are also not silver bullets. Ms. Halder said a material or construction method that works well in one region or for one type of building may not be appropriate elsewhere. Traditional practices may also have to be modified to meet contemporary requirements.

“Cement and concrete are extremely difficult to eliminate from contemporary construction. I cannot realistically tell a client constructing a ten-storey building to simply replace reinforced-concrete construction with soil,” Ms. Halder said. “The more realistic approach is to reduce dependence where appropriate and design the building and surrounding urban environment to minimise heat gain and heat storage.”

There are contemporary practitioners using lime, earth, mud, lime-surkhi, and other traditional or natural systems, she added. “The issue is less about the technologies having disappeared and more about the construction industry having developed an enormous ecosystem around cement”

(Monika Mondal is a freelance science and environment journalist. amonikamondal@gmail.com)



A view of the cement factory at village Mohanpura Jodhpura village in Rajasthan. S .M. Tayyab Hussain



The study generated more than 38,000 GPS locations, providing high-resolution data on seasonal elephant movements across multi-use landscapes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

GPS study aims to reduce human-animal conflicts in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

GPS study of elephant movements aims at reducing conflicts in Assam. A five-year satellite tracking study has provided new insights into how wild elephants navigate Assam’s forests, tea plantations, agricultural areas, and riverine habitats, yielding “crucial” data for the authorities to strengthen habitat protection and mitigate conflicts with humans.

Wildlife officials and conservation ecologists tracked four female-led herds and a solitary male elephant in three high-conflict districts of Udalguri, Sonitpur and Biswanath — all on the northern bank of the Brahmaputra River — between April 2021 and June 2026 for the “breakthrough” study.

The findings of the study, conducted by the Assam Forest Department and World Wide Fund for Nature-India (WWF-India), were published in a report titled *Tracking the Giants: Movement and Habitat-Use Patterns of GPS-Collared Elephants in Assam*.

“The study will help guide conservation planning, strengthen wildlife-friendly infrastructure and support safer coexistence between people and wildlife across Assam,” Assam’s Forest Minister, Jayanta Mallabaruah, said after releasing the report on the occasion of the 72nd Wildlife Week on Tuesday (October 6). The Minister told the 126-member Assam Assembly in July that human-elephant conflicts claimed 1,147 human lives and 246 elephants in the State since 2016. The study generated more than 38,000 GPS (Global Positioning System) locations, providing high-resolution data on seasonal elephant movements across multi-use landscapes.

According to the 2025 Synchronised All India Elephant Census, Assam remains the stronghold for Asian elephants in the northeastern region with an estimated population of 4,149 individuals.

“This report fills a major knowledge gap in terms of elephant presence and movement in the State. The findings of this study provide important baseline information on elephant-ranging patterns, particularly where they overlap with human land use,” Vinay Gupta, Assam’s Principal Chief Conservator of Forests-Wildlife and Chief Wildlife Warden, said.

Conservation strategies

Aritra Kshetry, who heads WWF-India’s Elephant Conservation Programme, said the GPS telemetry survey helped identify core natural and secondary habitats used by the collared elephants and revealed a strong seasonal pattern in their movements. “This information will guide effective management of human-elephant conflict, which requires a clearer understanding of where elephants move, how they use different habitats and land-use types, and how these patterns change across seasons,” he said.

Sonai-Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary, Behali Wildlife Sanctuary and Bornadi Wildlife Sanctuary emerged as important habitats extensively used by the collared elephants, a WWF-India statement said. At the same time, tea plantations served as significant movement pathways and secondary habitats, often bringing elephants close to people, it stated.

“Protected areas and reserve forests remained important elephant habitats for much of the year, with home ranges of female-led herds expanding during the paddy cropping season, a period also associated with high levels of human-elephant conflict,” the statement read.

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